

Proverbs: A Translation, Paraphrase, and Commentary {Incomplete}
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Version 0.1

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{Dedicated to}

Preface

Thousands of years have passed since the book of Proverbs was composed, so it is no insult to anyone's intelligence if at times Solomon's words of wisdom seem a bit opaque. This commentary hopes to assist readers in understanding the book. The following pages offer

- a brief introduction to the book;
- a fairly literal translation of the Hebrew original on the right;¹
- a very dynamic paraphrase; and

Not every question will be answered. But I hope that believers will come away from the present volume with a clearer picture of what this book of the Bible teaches as well as a continued eagerness to implement its wisdom.

Introduction

The book of Proverbs is a collection. Though the order of its contents is not random, it is not always easy to discern why items appear in the order that they do. Stated another way, it is not as though everything that concerns a certain topic (say, money management) is discussed comprehensively in one and only one section of the book before another topic (say, communication) is brought up. Rather, the various topics and ideas of the book frequently appear in new configurations. Proverbs is not so much an encyclopedia, but a kaleidoscope.

That said, it is not as though the book entirely lacks structure. An important aspect of the way the book has been written in this: the first nine chapters are a series of poetic monologues driving home again and again that wisdom is of *crucial* importance in life; then, starting with chapter 10 and running to the end of the book, there is a long sequence of aphorisms, most of which are expressed in two, parallel lines. (Particularly in Hebrew, these aphorisms are extremely concise—often 3-4 words per line—and sometimes riddle-like.) To oversimplify a bit, the first third of the book establishes why wisdom is important, and the other two-thirds of the book applies the principles of wisdom to everyday life.

Possibly the most important thing about the many proverbs found in this book is that they are proverbs, *not* promises. So, for example, when read in 13:11, “Wealth hastily gained quickly shrinks, / But he who gathers by hand increases [his holdings],” we are not thereby informed that in *every* case those who acquire wealth speedily lose it speedily, and that *without exception* hard work brings reward. What we are given is a general principle: hard work normally pays off with time, but get-rich-quick schemes tend to evaporate suddenly—not always, but often enough that this proverb is helpful.

It is also important to observe that many proverbs in the book describe what not what *should* be, but what *is* (in this fallen world) the case. Jesus calls on his servants to “be as shrewd as snakes and [yet] as

¹ The Hebrew base text for the translation is {SRO}. This edition, instead of more or less reproducing the text found in a single Hebrew manuscript, as is typically done, is based on a study of important ancient manuscripts and translations of the Old Testament. For this reason, some of the differences that appear between the translation offered in this commentary and those in wide use are due to textual variants, though most will simply be different ways of rendering or understanding the Hebrew.

blameless as doves” (Mat 10:16). We should not be blind to the dangers and problems around us.²

With few or no exceptions, the book of Proverbs assumes that its audience is male. There might be various reasons for this, but possibly the most salient reason is that some or all of the authors were kings who were preparing their sons one day to take the throne. Much of what is said can be either directly or with slight adjustment applied to the female follower of Christ.

Writing the book of Proverbs was a team effort. Solomon wrote most of it (1:1ff), and then someone added collected sayings of certain other wise men (22:17ff, 24:23ff). An early version of the book evidently circulated for some time in ancient Israel, and then in the days of King Hezekiah, certain other proverbs known to be Solomon's were added to it (25:1).³ Still later additions from other individuals appear later (30:1ff, 31:1ff). It is also widely, and probably correctly, thought that many of the proverbs are not Solomon's own compositions, but borrowing from others (the ancient world not generally being concerned with footnotes or works cited pages, these borrowings are not generally marked as such).

In Proverbs we constantly encounter terms like “fool” and “wise man.” The book early on (see especially 1:7) establishes that these terms are not—primarily at least—intellectual, but rather *moral*. This distinction is important for understanding the book (and understanding life). So, for example, there have been men of great intellectual ability who nevertheless cheated on their wives, to their eternal shame; on the other hand, there are people who know little, yet outshine many in their sincere love for God and devotion to others.

Proverbs has much to say about the (sometimes messy) realities of daily life. So we read of dirty feeding troughs, unkind shoppers, and vicious rumors. There is unblushing discussion of work ethic, money management, and interpersonal conflict. All that said, the various proverbs contained in this book, though many, hardly cover every nut and bolt of daily life. At the opening of a book discussing key New Testament passage on the doctrine of sanctification, Sinclair Ferguson says this: “In fact the New Testament has—at least compared to contemporary expectations—very little to say directly about the 'how-to' of the Christian life, although it is anything but lacking in the 'what to'. It is far more concerned with shaping our understanding, so that a new life style emerges organically, than it is with techniques—although, as we shall see, it certainly includes instructions on the way to a holy life, motivations for living it, and, yes, indications of how this can be accomplished” (x). What Ferguson says about sanctification in the New Testament also applies to wisdom in the book of Proverbs. The book of Proverbs does contain much that is hands-on, practical, down-to-earth; but more than seeking to pen a guidebook, Proverbs seeks to create a mind-set. That mindset is, above all, a mindset of receptivity to wisdom, whenever and wherever God presents it to us. Wisdom, frequently depicted in the first nine chapters of the book as a woman calling aloud in the city to all with ears to hear, invites readers to accept her way of life. “Once we respond to wisdom's gracious invitation, we must allow our character to be shaped by her and her values. Only then will we be ready to be God's person in God's world” (Wilson 141).

1:1-7 (Paraphrase)	1:1-7 (Translation)
Here follow [some of] the proverbs of Israel's King Solomon of Israel, David's son. This work intends to allow the reader to get a feel for wise and careful behavior and to model best practices. It is prudent to be receptive to correctives, and this receptivity leads to just and upright leadership. [Not only this, but] those who are untrained and inexperienced can [by pondering this book] make gains in the areas of perceptiveness, knowledge, and	1 Proverbs of Solomon, son of David, king of Israel— 2 To know wisdom and discipline; To understand words of discernment; 3 To receive the correction of prudence, [Along with] righteousness, justice, and uprightness; 4 To give to the naive perceptiveness, To the youth knowledge and forethought— 5 The wise will hear [these proverbs] and increase their acquisition [of wisdom],

² “*Balance* is another feature of [the] proverbs [in this book]. If all we had were the pointed sayings that prod us to work hard and acquire much... we could rationalize our compulsive greed and endemic drive to self-protection. But just when we begin to savor that temptation, another set of saying, equally pointed, goads us to use what our work has produced with lavish generosity to the needy” (Hubbard, 169).

³ 1 Ki 5:12 records that Solomon wrote 3,000 proverbs, so there were plenty to choose from!

thoughtfulness. [This book is not only for beginners, however:] Those who are [already] skilled in these matters will become more skillful still. [Finally,] this work aims to teach the reader to read with comprehension the maxims and parables of the wise. The foundation[al principle] of all of this knowledge is [easy to state]: Hold the Lord in reverence, knowing that only fools turn a blind eye to such wisdom and correction.	And the discerning will acquire [even more] astuteness— 6 [And] to understand a proverb and a riddle, The words the wise and their parables. 7 The fear of Yahweh is the beginning of knowledge, [But] wisdom and correction fools despise.
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Here Solomon states the purposes of his work. In the proverbs that make up the bulk of this book,⁴ the king of Israel aims to inculcate in his readers a mindset by which life can (and should) be lived well. The benefits will be many, both for first-time readers (v4) and long-standing students (v5).⁵

This introductory material stated, Solomon moves to the most important principle of the book: We must honor God (v7). The Hebrew verb here often means “to be frightened of,” but since we are told to love God (Deut 6:5, etc.), we can surmise that Solomon does *not* mean knee-knocking terror. Even so, the boundless power and absolute authority of God—death and life are in his hands (1 Sam 2:6)—means that his decrees must be held fast, not forgotten. When God speaks, we will listen, if we know what is good for us. The good life is a life that is lived differently than the life that would be lived if God was not watching. Ignoring God is the stupidest thing a person could do.

1:8-19 (Paraphrase) {}	1:8-19 (Translation) 8 Listen, my son, to your father's discipline, And do not leave aside your mother's instruction. 9 For they are a garland of grace for your head, And a pendant for your neck. 10 My son, if sinners entice you, Do not go! 11 If they say, “Come with us! “Let us lie in wait for blood, “We will for no reason lie in wait to ambush the innocent. 12 “We will swallow up the living like Sheol, “And [we will swallow] those with integrity like those who go down to the pit. 13 “We will find every precious treasure; “We will fill our houses with spoils [of war]. 14 “Cast your lot in with us! “We will all have one money bag.” 15 My son, do not go on the road with them; Refuse for your foot to follow their path. 16 For their feet run to evil, And they rush to spill blood. 17 Indeed, without cause a net is spread In the eyes of every winged creature. 18 But their lie in wait for their own blood;
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⁴ Other authors contributed portions of the book (see the Introduction).

⁵ Many good books can be read once and passed on, but the Bible should be read many times over!

	They lie in ambush for their own lives. 19 {}
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“What fools despise (v. 7) is a source of elegance, delight, and beauty [v. 9]. No yoke pictured here. No back-to-the-wall, nose-to-the-grindstone kind of clenched-jaw obedience” (Hubbard, 48-49).

We must listen to the voice of reason (here represented by the parental⁶ advice cited in v8), both in view of its benefits (v9), and because there are other voices that we must *not* listen to (v10ff): Some evildoers thrill in the perverted pleasure of wooing others to join them in their wickedness.

Prominent in the evildoers' sales pitch is a combination of violence and greed. “An Arabian proverb says, 'Covetousness has for its mother unlawful desire, for its daughter injustice, and for its friend violence.' Is it any wonder that our modern covetous society witnesses so much injustice and violence? The only cure is to change the heart and replace the desire for things with devotion to God, and only Jesus Christ can perform that miracle” (Wiersbe 184). In the end, those who desire the destruction of others will discover the destruction of *themselves* (v18). Unjust “gain is attractive and enticing when it is offered, but it takes away rather than gives life. It promises life but delivers death” (Wilson 67).

1:20-33 (Paraphrase) It is as if wisdom is a woman who—up on the walls of the city, on the street corners, and every place people will be in earshot—calls out: “You who are naive, leave you naivety behind! You who are scornful, stop making irreverence your plaything! You who are fools, stop turning your back on genuine understanding! Accept my constructive criticism, and you'll be amazed at how {}. But be warned: If you ignore my words, don't expect sympathy from me whom you spurned when your time comes, when everything comes crashing down around you, and Judgment Day arrives. You'll wish for me, but it'll be too late, and your hatred of the ways of the Lord will have been your own undoing. But those who accept my instruction will enjoy true peace; nothing will truly terrorize them.”	1:20-33 (Translation) 20 Wisdom raises a shout outdoors; In the streets she raises her voice. 21 On top of the walls she calls out; In doorways of the city gates she speaks her words: 22 “How long, naive ones, will you love naivety, “And mockers delight themselves in mockery, “And fools hate knowledge? 23 “Return to my reproach! “Watch: I will pour out for you my spirit; “I will make my words known to you. 24 “[But] because I called out, but you refused, “[And] I extend my hand, but you did not listen; 25 “[Because] you ignored by counsel, “And were not willing to heed my reproach, 26 “I also will laugh at your catastrophe; “I will laugh when your dread comes. 27 “When your dread comes like Sheol, “And your catastrophe comes like a gale. “When trouble and trials come upon you. 28 “Then you will call to me and I will not answer; “You will seek me and will not find me, 29 “In exchange for how you hated knowledge, “And did not choose the fear of Yahweh. 30 “They were not willing to listen to my counsel; “They despised my every reproach, 31 “And they will eat the fruit of their ways, “And from their schemes they will be satisfied. 32 “For the apostasy of the naive will murder them, “And the inattention of fools will destroy them.
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⁶ Hubbard (49) observes that there is “no similar reference to [a] mother as teacher in Babylonian or Egyptian wisdom literature.” There was a lot of prejudice against women in the ancient middle east, but the Holy Spirit allowed the writers of Scripture to rise above this prejudice, at least in their best moments.

	33 “But he who listens to me will dwell securely, “And will live at peace, dreading no evil.”
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This passage employs the literary device of personification (the portrayal, for artistic and/or rhetorical reasons, of something that is not human by a human figure). In this way, wisdom—which might seem dry, abstract, and distant—becomes emotive, visible, and vivid. If you could look wisdom in the eye, you would, momentarily at least, stop in your tracks. If wisdom had a voice, this is what she would say.

And what does Wisdom say? She certainly is not afraid to call it like she sees it (v22)—her listeners have a natural predisposition to naivety ({{cite concerning *peti*}}). Yet though her words might seem harsh, they do not consign people to a life of failure but invite them to receive an outpouring of spirit (v23); she is, in fact, exceedingly generous. Her message is sufficiently widely disseminated (vv20-21; cf. Ac 14:17, Col 1:6) that if we refuse her message, we will have only ourselves to blame (vv24-32). As much as she elaborates on that note of warning, however, she does end on a positive note (v33).

Additional Note

Hebrew has no no specific word for “mind” or “brain.” Typically, in utterances where an English speaker might be inclined to use such words, Hebrew will use the word לֵב. This word is usually translated “heart”—whether the physical organ or (more commonly in the Old Testament) the inner emotional, cognitive, and/or spiritual functions of a rational being. There is a constant (and fruitful) ambiguity in the book between “mind” and “heart”; when we encounter one of these terms in the translation, there is a good chance we could substitute the other term.

	2:1-22 (Translation) 1 My son, if you will receive my words, And store up my commandments within you, 2 To incline your ear to wisdom— If you will incline your heart to discernment— 3 For if you cry out for discernment, And raise your voice for discernment— 4 If you seek it like silver, And search for it like treasure, 5 Then you will discern the fear of Yahweh, And you will find the knowledge of God. 6 For Yahweh gives wisdom; From his mouth are knowledge and discernment, 7 And he stores up success for the upright, And benefit for those who walk in integrity, 8 Keeping the ways of justice, And guarding the path of his loyal ones. 9 Then you will discern righteousness and justice, And you will make straight the path of every good thing. 10 For wisdom will come to your heart, And knowledge will be pleasant to your soul. 11 Forethought will post a guard over you; Discernment will keep you safe, 12 To deliver you from the evil way, From the man speaking perverse things, 13 [And from] those who forsake upright paths, Walking the paths of darkness,
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	14 [And from] those who rejoice to do evil— They delight in evil perversity, 15 Whose paths they twist, And they are crooked in their ways— 16 [And] to deliver you from the wicked woman, From the unfaithful woman, whose words flatter. 17 Who abandons the companion of her youth, And her God's covenant forgets. 18 For her house has sunk down to Sheol, And her paths lead to ghosts. 19 None who go to her will return, Or reach the paths of life. 20 [I say all this] that you may travel in the good way, And keep righteous paths [before you]. 21 For the upright will inherit the earth, And those with integrity will remain left in it. 22 But the wicked will be cut off from the earth, And the treacherous will be torn from it.
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The key thing about wisdom is to want it (vv1-4). Those who ask, receive (vv5-6; cf. Mat 7:7)—assuming they ask out of a sincere desire for a godly life (vv7-8; cf. Jm 4:3). Many benefits will ensue (vv9-15), not least rescue from the seductions of the adulterous woman (vv16-19).

The goal is to remain on the “good path” (v20), or what Jesus will call the “narrow gate” (Mat 7:13). God's good earth is—to an extent even now, and fully so in the future—for the righteousness, not the unrighteous (vv21-22; cf. Rev 21:1-8).

Additional Notes

Some translations, in their main text or their footnotes, use adjectives like “stranger” and “foreign” to describe the woman in 2:16 (and in some similar verses elsewhere), but this misrepresents the Hebrew, and incorrectly projects xenophobia onto ancient Israelite attitudes toward marriage (on both these matters, see Waltke 1:120-122).

Some commentators see in the adulterous woman a metaphor for sin itself, a counterpart to the personification of wisdom that we will meet in 8:1ff. This interpretation is possible, but (1) the adulterous woman is in the present passage one of *several* dangers the wise individual will be glad to have avoided, not the *only* such danger (it would not make sense to say, “What for various sins, among them sin”); and (2) in a very similar passage (5:7-23) the antidote for the seductions of this woman is not wisdom *per se*, but the embraces of one's own wife. So it seems more likely that the warning should be read in a fairly literal manner. (The situation in 9:13-17 is different, since there the literary device of personification is clearly being used.) The upshot of this is that of all the things to take special measures to safeguard, marriage ranks very high (so also Heb 13:4).

	3:1-10 (Translation) 1 My son, do not forget my instruction, And let your heart keep my commandments. 2 For length of days and years of life And peace will be added to you. 3 Do not let loyal love and truth leave you: Bind them on your neck; Write them on your heart's tablet. 4 Thus you will find favor and good sense In the eyes of God and of mankind.
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	5 Trust toward Yahweh with all your heart, And do not lean on your discernment. 6 Know him in all your ways, And for his part, he will straighten your paths. 7 Do not be wise in your eyes; Fear God and turn from evil. 8 It will be healing for your navel, And drink for your bones. 9 Honor Yahweh from your wealth, And from the first part of all your income, 10 That your treasuries may be full to overflowing, And your vat may break from holding so much juice.
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Solomon is not looking for “lip service or outward show but... [obedience] is to become an integral part of the discipline, written on the heart” (Hubbard, 70). {}

Additional Note

The word (תירוש) translated “juice” in v10 is obscure. It might refer to some kind of wine. On the topic of alcohol in Proverbs in general, see on {}.

	3:11-18 (Translation) 11 The discipline of Yahweh, my son, do not reject, And do not lose heart at his reproof. 12 For the one he loves, Yahweh reproves, And brings pain[ful correction] to the son he delights in. 13 How blessed is the man who finds wisdom, And the man who attains discernment! 14 For its profit is better than the profit of silver, And its income is better than fine gold. 15 It is more precious than pearls, And no treasures equal it. 16 Length of days are in its right hand, And in its left hand are wealth and honor. 17 Its ways are ways of pleasantness, And all its paths are peace. 18 It is a tree of life to all who take hold of it, And those who grasp it find happiness.
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	3:19-35 (Translation) 19 Yahweh in wisdom founded the earth, Establishing the heavens with discernment. 20 In his knowledge the deep was broken open, And the clouds drip rain. 21 My son, do not let them slip from your gaze; Guard [your hold on] sagacity and forethought 22 That they might be life for your soul, And grace for your neck.
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	23 Then you will walk in peace on your way, And your foot will not strike [a rock]. 24 If you sit, you will not be in dread, And you will lie down and your sleep will be pleasant. 25 Do not fear sudden terror, Or the desolation of the wicked when it comes. 26 For Yahweh will be your confidence, And he will guard your foot from being ensnared. 27 Do not refuse good from the one it is due to While it is in the power of your hands to do so. 28 Do not say to your neighbor, “Go, and return, “For tomorrow I will give it to you,” While it is with you [the whole time]. 29 Do not plan evil against your neighbor When he is dwelling peacefully with you. 30 Do not strive with a man for no reason— Without a doubt he will return your evil to you! 31 Do not be jealous of a violent man, And do not choose any of his ways [for yourself]. 32 For the crooked man is an abomination to Yahweh, But Yahweh’s friendship is with the upright. 33 The curse of Yahweh is in the house of the wicked, But he will bless the dwelling of the righteous. 34 God mocks mockers, But to the humble he gives grace. 35 The wise will inherit honor, But fools raise up dishonor.
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{Re vv28-29, “An offense against your neighbor is a fence between you and God.”⁷}

	4:1-19 (Translation) 1 Listen, O sons, to the discipline of a father, And pay attention, so as to know discernment. 2 For the acquisition of good I give to you; Do not abandon my instruction. 3 For I [myself] was a son to my father, Tender and unique to my mother. 4 He taught me and said to me, “Let me words take hold of your heart, “Keep to commandments that you may live: 5 “Acquire wisdom! Acquire discernment! “Do not forget, and do not incline away from the words of my mouth. 6 “Let it not leave you, and it will guard you; “Love it, and it will keep you. 7 “The beginning of wisdom: Acquire wisdom! “And in all your acquisitions: Acquire discernment!
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⁷ I read this somewhere, I think in a copy of the *Our Daily Bread* devotional.

	8 “Lift it up in praise, and it will exalt you; “Honor it, for [then] it will treasure you. 9 “It will give your head a garland of grace; “It will bestow on you a crown of beauty. 10 “Listen, my son, and receive my words, “That you may multiply your days. 11 “I have taught you the way of wisdom. “I have taught you to walk in the paths of uprightness. 12 “If you walk, your foot will not be constrained, “And if you run, you will not stumble. 13 “Take hold of discipline, and do not slacken your grip; “Keep it, for it is your life! 14 “Do not go in the path of the wicked, “And do not proceed on the path of the evil. 15 “Leave it be, and do not travel on it; “Turn away, and travel elsewhere. 16 “For they cannot sleep unless they have done evil, “And their sleep is torn away [from them] unless they have caused others to fall. 17 “For they eat the bread of lawlessness, “And they drink the wine of the violent. 18 “But the path of the righteous is like the light of dawn: “It grows brighter and brighter until the day is established. 19 “The way of the wicked is like darkness: “They do not [even] know what it is they stumble over.”
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“Verses 10-13 set out the positive consequences of choosing the way of wisdom, beginning with a call to hear (v. 10) and concluding with a mini-summary in verse 13 – keep hold of instruction, do not let her go, guard her, for she is your life. The observation is again made that wisdom leads to a long, rich life (v. 10; see 3:12; 9:11) not as a promise but rather as a common outcome of sensible living. The focus is not on the many exceptions (e.g. those caused by injustice, war or genetics) that we know about, but on the general principle that, despite the many variables, living in accordance with God’s wise values will typically lead to good results... God’s wisdom works in his world” (Wilson 92-93).

	4:20-27 (Translation) 20 My son, pay attention to my words; Incline your ear to my sayings. 21 Do not let them slip from your gaze. Keep them in the midst of your heart. 22 For they are life to those who find them, And healing for all of his body. 23 Keep your heart more closely than you guard anything, For from it are the goings-out of life.
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	24 Turn aside from yourself a crooked mouth; Keep far from you perverse lips. 25 Your eyes must gaze straight ahead, And your eyelids be straight ahead of you. 26 Plant your foot on level ground, And make sure all your ways are established. 27 Do not incline to the right or to the left; Turn your foot from evil.
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{ } Among other things, this passage makes clear that it is not simply for the sound of truth to reach our ears—we must lean in to hear truth, and make every effort to grasp it and retain it. “Our generation so exalts good communication that virtually all the weight for getting the point across rests on the speaker. This is neither fair nor realistic” (Hubbard 199).

- “Better one eye”

jjj

	5:1-23 (Translation) 1 My son, pay attention to my wisdom; Incline your ear to my discernment, 2 So that you can guard forethought, And that your lips might guard knowledge. 3 For the lips of a wicked woman drip honey, And her mouth is more slippery than oil, 4 Yet her end is as bitter as wormwood, As sharp the sword's blade. 5 Her feet go down to Death; Sheol take hold of her steps. 6 The way of life she does not tread; Her footsteps totter while she is unaware.⁸ 7 And now, O sons, listen to me, And do not turn aside from the words of my mouth. 8 [Beware the adulterous woman;] keep your way far from her, And do not approach the door of her house, 9 Lest you give your youth to others, And your years to a cruel individual; 10 Lest strangers be satisfied with your strength, And your toil be in a foreign house, 11 And you grown at your end, As your flesh and what remains of you meets its end, 12 And you say, “How I have hated discipline, “And my heart has despised reproof! 13 “And I did not listen to the voice of my teachers, “Nor did I incline my ear to my instructors; 14 “Suddenly did I find myself involved in every evil In the midst of the assembly and congregation.” 15 Drink water from your [own] cistern,
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⁸ In Hebrew there is a paragraph break at this point, but given the use of pronouns in v8, the break evidently does not mark off distinct sections but rather call special attention to ועתה (“And now”).

	And [drink] streams from your own well. 16 Should your springs break out into the open, [Or your] streams of water in the streets? 17 Let them be for you alone, And not for strangers with you. 18 Let your spring be blessed, And rejoice in the wife of your youth! 19 A loving doe and a graceful ibex, Let her love saturate you always! Be drunk with her love continually. 20 For why should you be drunk with a wicked woman, Or an unfaithful woman? 21 For before Yahweh are the ways of a man, And all his paths he weighs in the balances. 22 The wicked man—his [own] iniquities will capture him, And in the cords of his [own] sin he will be seized. 23 He will die for his lack of discipline, And in the abundance of his folly he goes astray.
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{ } But the problem is not sexuality activity in itself, because the antidote that wisdom prescribes (v15ff) is sexual activity. “This sexual activity is within the context of marriage (*the wife of your youth*, v. 18b), and flows out of a relationship of love (*her love*, v. 19c). This is not simply a rational decision to be faithful to your spouse (although that is a good thing), but rather a physical and emotional ‘intoxication’, which so characterizes your relationship that it happens *at all times... always...* Be intoxicated with the right woman, not the wrong one” (Wilson 104).

What you choose to do with your sexuality has ultimate significance (v21ff). Without holiness no one will see God (Heb 12:14b).

{ } “When adultery enters a marriage, everybody loses” (Wiersbe 66).
{Cf. 1 Cor 7}

Additional Note

In v19 the first occurrence of the word “love” is typically translated “breasts.” For reasons that need not detain us here, I do not think that this is the most accurate translation of the Hebrew (טַף). It is not the case, however, that Scripture shies away from the fact that males typically find female breasts attractive. Notably, this fact is cast in a positive light in the Song of Songs (4:5). Sexuality is something that should be discussed with discretion and sensitivity, but the Church should not ignore this part of the human experience or focus only on its abuses.

	6:1-5 (Translation) 1 My son, if you have put up a security for your neighbor, Have shaken hands for a stranger, 2 Have become ensnared in the words of your mouth, Have become trapped in the words of your mouth, 3 Then do this, my son, and be delivered (For you have entered into your neighbor's hand): Go, rush speedily to your neighbor. 4 Do not give sleep to your eyes,
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	Or slumber to your eyelids. 5 Be delivered like a gazelle from the [hunter's] hand, And like a bird from the hand of the trap.
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	6:6-11 (Translation) 6 Go to the ant, lazy person, See its ways, and be wise: 7 It has no overseer Administrator, or ruler, 8 [Yet] prepares its sustenance in summer, [And] gathers its foot in harvest [time]. 9 How long, O lazy one, will you lie down? When will you arise from your sleep? 10 “A little sleep, a little slumber, “A little clasping of the hands to sleep.” 11 And your poverty will come like a robber, And your lack [will come] like an armed man.
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Many people hate hard work (vv9-10). But laziness leads to disaster (v11). Here a man can learn from someone much smaller than himself, the ant; the ant needs no one barking orders to get ready for future needs in advance (vv6-8).

Additional Note

{Species of ant referred to}

	6:12-15 (Translation) 12 An evil man, a man of iniquity, Who goes around with twisted mouth, 13 Who winks with his eyes, Who scrapes with his feet, Who points with his fingers, 14 Perversity in his heart, Devising evil always— He shoots off strife— 15 For these reasons his [day of] disaster will come suddenly; He will be broken, with none to heal, in an instant.
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	6:16-19 (Translation) 16 Six things Yahweh hates— [No,] seven are abominations to his soul:
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⁹ Hubbard (98) offers this reflection: “Perhaps my inherent caution is owed to the fact that my dad, warm-spirited and kindhearted preacher that he was, almost always came out short in such financial matters. But I have developed strong convictions about the risks of financial involvement between ministers and their friends or parishioners. Successful deals may engender feelings of obligation; unsuccessful ones may breed hostility. We learn from the teacher to take hat in hand and beg for mercy when we must; we also learn the wisdom of avoiding obligations whose outcomes augurs pain.”

	17 [1] Eyes that are lifted up, [2] A lying tongue, [3] And hands that shed innocent blood; 18 [4] A heart devising evil plans, [5] Feet that rush to evil, 19 [6] A false witness breathing out lies, And [7] one who scatters dissension between brothers.
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Solomon here makes a list of things that deeply offend and grieve God. Clearly, this list is a sample, yet does much to encapsulate in a handful of words the kinds of things that the righteous ruler of the universe hates. Solomon adds punch to this itemization of evil by starting with one number and then upping the ante: “There are six things... no, wait, make that seven!”

The first item on the list is arrogance. God, who is “near the brokenhearted, and saves the crushed in spirit” (Ps 34:18), whose Son came into the world to be lain on a manger (Lk 2:7), and whose Spirit brings “love” and “gentleness” (Gal 5:22-23) fixes his gaze on the “humble” (Isa 66:2). Self-importance and autonomy are sins of cosmic significance (Rom 1:18-25). On the list of terrible sins, pride of place goes to pride itself.

Second, there is deceit. God “never lies” (Tit 1:2). It is only fitting for him who made everything good (Gen 1:31) and has nothing to hide (1 Jn 1:5) to be a truth-teller, and for his people to follow his example.

Third, there is murder. The word “innocent” highlights the fact that what God abhors is not killing of any kind—at times, capital punishment is necessary (Gen 9:6). But when someone has done nothing deserving death and yet suffers, God burns with anger. In an age of rampant gun violence, wars unjustly waged, and other forms of murder, it must be understood that God does not shrug his shoulders, but prepares to bring justice at the proper time (Ps 94:23).

Fourth, there is scheming. While temptation is not itself sin (Heb 4:15), there are sins of the mind (cf. Mat 5:28). God plans “good” (Jer 29:11). The human mind has been crafted to contemplate the blessed creator (Ps 27:4) and to steward God's beautiful creation (cf. Gen 2:19); to make that mind a machine devoted to the manufacture of wickedness is itself wicked.

Fifth, some people not only do the wrong thing, but *rush* to do evil. It is wrong to succumb to peer pressure, or to lash out after repeated abuses; but to slide into sin *suddenly* is something else entirely. God is slow to anger (Ex 34:6), and his people should be slow to sin.

Sixth, some people resort to perjury. Lies in general were already condemned (item 2 in the list), but here special mention is made of lies in a *judicial* setting. Deceit in the court of law lends itself particularly to abuse of the poor by the rich, a practice which the Bible constantly condemns. God's Son became poor (2 Cor 8:9). In the United States, resorting to the judicial system is far too frequent, as are false statements.

The seventh and final item on the list is divisiveness. God's people in particular ought to “dwell together in unity” (Ps 133:1). In this present polarized age, eschewing divisiveness is all the more imperative. (For some valuable tips on how to do this, see Shorey *passim*.)

	6:20-26 (Translation) 20 Keep, my son, the commandment of your father, And do not abandon the instruction of your mother. 21 Bind them on your heart continually; Make them a necklace on your neck. 22 When you go about your day, it will lead you; When you lie down, it will post a guard over you, And when you awake, it will be your meditation. 23 For the commandment is a lamp, and the instruction gives light; And reproof and discipline are the way of life. 24 Keeping you from the evil woman,
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	From the smoothness of the unfaithful woman's tongue. 25 Do not desire her beauty in your heart, And do not receive her eyelids. 26 For the price of a prostitute extends as far as a loaf of bread, {Yet} {on this verse cf. 23:28's feminine singular after v27's zonah in one line and nokhriyah in the second line?}
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	6:27-35 (Translation) 27 Can a man scoop up burning coals in the arms Without his clothes burning up? 28 Or can a man walk on coals And his feet not be scorched? 29 So it is with the man who go in to the wife of his neighbor: None will be found guiltless who touch her. 30 No one would despise a thief when he steals To satisfy himself when he is hungry, 31 But he [who commits adultery] will pay sevenfold; All the treasure of his house he will give! 32 He who commits adultery with a woman lacks sense; He makes her into a destroyer of his own soul. 33 Blows and shame he finds, And his reproach will not be erased. 34 For the heat of a man provokes him to jealous action, And he will not show mercy on the day of vengeance; 35 He will not accept any ransom, Nor will he accept it when you multiply bribes.
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Jjj

“This speech needs no specific illustration [from current events]. Your mind like mine has conjured up a dozen memories of talented, dedicated, charming persons who committed emotional suicide and revoked their own credentials as Christian leaders by seeking gratification with persons off-limits to them. If Henry Kissinger's maxim is correct—‘power is the ultimate aphrodisiac’—then leaders face a special responsibility to curb their lusts... Were Proverbs being written for our times it would alert us to the dangers of transference and countertransference where authority figure and eager follower, say counselor and counselee, entertain legitimate feelings for and expectations of each other. What starts as an arm's length face-to-face relationship tragically ends, all too often, as an intimate embrace more destructive to both parties than any outraged mother bear could inflict on a dog that tampered with her cub” (Hubbard, 107).

	7:1-27 (Translation) 1 My son, pay close attention to my words, And my commandments treasure within you.
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	2 Keep my commandments so that you may live, And my instruction like the pupil of your eye. 3 Bind them on your fingers; Write them on the tablets of your heart. 4 Say to wisdom, “You are my sister!” And call discernment your friend. 5 This is to guard you from the wicked woman, From the unfaithful woman whose words are smooth. 6 For through a window in my house, Through the lattice I looked down, 7 I gazed upon the naive; I discerned among the young men A fellow lacking sense, 8 Going through the marketplace by her corner, And walking on the street to her house 9 In the twilight, as day became evening, In the eye of night and of darkness. 10 And there came a woman to meet him In the dress of a prostitute and with guarded heart; 11 Murmuring and rebellious, Her feet do not dwell in her house. 12 At times outside and at times in the streets, At every corner she lies in wait. 13 And she took hold of him and kissed him; She made her face firm and said to him, 14 “I have peace offerings; “I have fulfilled my vows today. 15 “So I went out to meet you, “To search out your face so that I could find you. 16 “I have spread blankets on my couch, “Dark and spun with yarn from Egypt. 17 “I have sprinkled my bed “With myrrh, aloe, and cinnamon. 18 “Come, let us overflow with love until morning; “Let us revel in romance! 19 “For my husband is not at home; “He is far away on a journey. 20 “He has taken the money bag with him; “He will [not] come home [until] at the [time of] full moon.” 21 She inclined him with her full effort; With the smoothness of her lips she led him. 22 He suddenly goes after her; Like a sheep to the slaughter he proceeds, And like a jumping [in]to [the arms of] the one who will bind it [for sacrifice], 23 Until an arrow pierces his liver, Like a bird hastens to a trap [he hastens on to her house],
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	And he does not know that he is forfeiting his soul. 24 And now, O sons, listen to me; Pay attention to the words of my mouth: 25 Do not let your heart shift toward her ways; Do not wander in her paths. 26 For many are the dead that she has slain; All her slain are skeletons. 27 The ways of Sheol are in her house; These ways go down to the houses of Death.
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	Pr 8:1-21 (Translation) 1 Does not Wisdom call out, And [does not] Discernment raise her voice? 2 On the top of the high points above the street, [And] at the crossroads she takes her stand; 3 By the gate in front of the city, [And] at the entrance of the doors she calls out: 4 “To you, O people, I call out; “And my voice is to the sons of Adam. 5 “Understand, O naive, perceptiveness, “And fools, understand thoughtfulness. 6 “Listen, for I will speak what is right, “And the opening of my lips is uprightness. 7 “For my mouth breathes out truth, And wickedness it what my mouth reproaches. 8 “All the words of my mouth are [spoken] in righteousness; “Nothing in them are twisted or perverted. 9 “All of them are appropriate for the one with discernment; “And upright to those find knowledge. 10 “Receive my reproof sooner than [you accept] silver, “And knowledge sooner than the finest gold. 11 “For wisdom is better than pearls, “And no treasures equal it. 12 “I, Wisdom, dwell with Perceptiveness, “And I [easily] find knowledge and forethought. 13 “The fear of Yahweh is hating evil, “[Also] pride, and pridefulness, and the evil way, “And I [also] hate perversity. 14 “Mine are counsel and success; “I am understanding; mine is strength. 15 “By me kings govern, “And rulers issue righteous decrees. 16 “By me princes administrate, “And nobles judge the land. 17 “I love those who love me,
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	“And those who seek me will find me. 18 “Riches and honor are with me, “[And] great wealth and righteousness. 19 “My fruit is better than the very finest gold, “And my harvest [is better] than the finest silver. 20 “In the way of righteousness I walk, “In the midst of the paths of justice. 21 “This causes those who love me to inherit real value, “And I will fill their storage places.”
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jjj

	Pr 8:22-31 22 “Yahweh acquired me at the [very] beginning of his way; “[He acquired me] before his [most] ancient works. 23 “[I, Wisdom,] was installed [to this key role] from the beginning, “From before [the foundation of] the earth. 24 “Before there were depths [of the sea] I was born; “Before there were springs, [or] channels of water. 25 “Before the mountains had been set in their place, “Or the hills had been given birth, 26 “[And] while the earth and [its] open fields had not yet been made, “And the sum of the world's dust [had not yet been fashioned]. 27 “When he established the heavens, I was there; “[I was there] when he inscribed a circle on the face of the oceanic abyss; 28 “When he strengthened the clouds above; “When he firmed up the fountains of the deep; 29 “When he assigned to the sea its boundary— “And the waters do not defy his command— “[And] when he assigned the foundations of the earth.” 30 “I was at his side like a {faithfully}.¹⁰ “I was an object of delight day by day, “Playing before him continually, 31 “Playing on the whole of his earth, “And my delight was with the children of Adam.”
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Additional Note

Among the church fathers it was generally taken for granted that the speaker in this passage is the pre-incarnate Christ. This assumption led to a firestorm of controversy, for if Christ is spoken of here, v22 seems to imply that Jesus did *not* exist from all eternity, but rather was a creature that God formed sometime between eternity past and the fashioning of the present world. Many of the church fathers argued—and some still do argue (e.g.

¹⁰ For the translation see Waltke (1:417-420).

Steinmann, 198-199, 203-210, 214-229)—that (1) the passage *does* refer to Christ, but (2) does *not* imply that Christ is a creature. But the first of these two suppositions is most likely *incorrect*, making debates over the second moot. Bypassing discussion of v22—a discussion that becomes exceedingly technical (see Waltke 408-409 for a concise introduction)—we can note that throughout the first several chapters of Proverbs, wisdom is frequently personified (see the comments on 1:20-33). It is most consistent, then, to view this passage the same way (cf. Wilson 124-127): The poem is about wisdom, not Jesus. Therefore, it does not describe Jesus as being something less than eternally, fully divine. Here as elsewhere, sound exegesis safeguards orthodox christology.

{}	8:32-36 (Translation) 32 And now, O sons, listen to me, For blessed are they who pay close attention to my ways. 33 Listen to discipline, and be wise, And do not ignore it 34 How blessed is the man who listens to me, Keeping a close watch on my doors day by day, [And] closely observing the doorposts of my entrances. 35 For those who have found me have found life, And have found favor from Yahweh. 36 Those who bypass me engage in violence against their own soul; All who hate me love death.
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“Wisdom has made her case; they must now make their choices. Her self-descriptions are not just erudite lectures, learned discourses on the sequence of creation. They are motivations, impassioned arguments designed to evoke an obedient response. Discipleship is not just studying; it is deciding. ‘Hear’ or ‘disdain’—those are the options, whether it is wisdom calling ‘Listen to me’ or Jesus, the greater Wisdom, calling ‘Follow me’” (Hubbard, 126).

{}	9:1-9 (Translation) 1 Wisdom has built her house; She has hewn her seven pillars. 2 She has slaughtered her livestock [for the feast], She has mixed her wine, And has prepared her table. 3 She has sent out her female servants. She calls out on the high points of the town: 4 “He who is naive, let him turn aside here; “As for the one lacking in sense, I will speak to him. 5 “Come, take part in my feast, “And drink the wine I have mixed! 6 “Abandon naivety, and live, “And go straight on the path of discernment. 7 “He who disciplines a scoffer gets [only] dishonor for himself, “And he who reproves a wicked man does so only as a blemish upon himself. 8 “Do not reprove a scoffer, so that he does not hate
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	you; “[Instead,] reprove a wise man so that he will love you. 9 “Give [instruction] to a wise man, and he will become even wiser; “Make things known to a righteous man, and he will acquire all the more [knowledge].”
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	9:10-18 (Translation) 10 “The beginning of wisdom is the fear of Yahweh, “And the knowledge of the holy one is understanding. 11 “For in me[, Wisdom,] your days will become many, “And years of life will be added to you. 12 “If you are wise, you will be wise to your own benefit, “And if you scoff, you will be the only one to bear it. 13 “Lady Foolishness mutters naivety– “Yet she does not know a thing– 14 “And she sits at the entrance to her house, “On a chair at the high points of the town, 15 “So that she can call out to those traveling on the road, “[And to] those going straight on their way: 16 “He who is naive, let him turn aside here; “And as for the one lacking in sense, I will speak to him. 17 “‘Stolen water is sweet, “‘And secret bread is pleasant.’ 18 “Yet they do not know that ghosts are there; “It is in the valleys of Sheol that they have called to her.”
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Wisdom continues her appeal. After the reminder that reverence for God is the starting point for wisdom (and therefore foolishness in the Proverbs sense of the term is not lack of intelligence in the mind, but lack of reverence for God in heaven), she points out that her way of life leads to life, while Foolishness’ doorway is the doorway to death. Inclining toward God or way from God sets one on a trajectory with very, very long-term consequences. “I read about a dirt-road intersection in the prairies of Canada where somebody had posted this sign: ‘Be careful what rut you take–you’ll be on it a long time!’” (Wiersbe 153).

	10:1 (Translation) [Here follow] proverbs of Solomon: A wise son makes his father glad, But a foolish son is the grief of his mother.
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At this point there is a major shift in the style (though not the message) of Proverbs. The first line here is a heading, making the transition away from the lengthy appeals of the previous chapters and toward a series of pithy maxims about wisdom.

The first such maxim is that wisdom in a child leads to happiness in a parent (and foolishness leads to sadness). Several things about the proverbs of Solomon are illustrated by the second and third lines here:

- The proverbs tend to come in two lines, often with the second line stating the inverse of the first.
- The proverbs prioritize concision over clarity (in Hebrew, each line is only four words in length).
- The proverbs are generalizations (sad to say, some parents are indifferent to their childrens' character).
- The proverbs generally focus on wisdom as a general aim rather than specific plans of action.

Granting that in ancient Israel family ties and preserving the honor of the family were among the highest of priorities, this particular proverb underscores the importance and benefits of choosing a life of wisdom.

	10:2 (Translation) The treasuries of wickedness bring no benefit; But righteousness delivers from death.
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	10:3 (Translation) Yahweh does not allow the soul of the righteous to go hungry, But he pushes away the desire of the wicked.
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	10:4 (Translation) Poverty makes a lazy hand, But the hand of the diligent brings riches.
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	10:5 (Translation) He who gathers in the summer is a wise son; He who sleeps in the harvest is a son who brings shame.
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	10:6 (Translation) Blessings are on the head of the righteous, But the mouth of wicked conceals lies.
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	10:7 (Translation) The memory of the righteous is a blessing, But the name of the wicked rots.
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{ (Protestant Christianity tends to neglect the first part of this verse, while Catholic and Orthodox Christianity tend to take it to extremes.)

	10:8 (Translation) A wise heart receives commandments, But foolish lips come to ruin.
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10:9 (Paraphrase) {	10:9 (Translation) He who walks in integrity walks securely, But he who perverts his ways will break into a sweat.
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}

	10:10 (Translation) He who winks his eye hands out grief, And foolish lips incite trouble.
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}

	10:11 (Translation) A spring of life is the mouth of the righteous, But the mouth of the wicked conceals violence.
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	10:12 (Translation) Hatred stirs up strife, But love covers all transgressions.
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}

	10:13 (Translation) In the lips of a discerning person wisdom is found, But a rod is for the back of a person lacking in sense.
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“The first line is not a tautology... if your mind is enlightened wisdom will overflow into your words, and so into other lives (cf. verse 11). If your mind is closed, God will still deal with you, but by force: cf. Psalm 32:8, 9” (Kidner 83).

	10:14 (Translation) The wise treasure knowledge, But as for the foolish mouth: Ruin is near.
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}

	10:15 (Translation) Wealth is the fortified city of a rich man; The poverty of the poor is their ruin.
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	10:16 (Translation) The work of the righteous is for life; The income of the wicked is for sin.
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	10:17 (Translation) The way to life carefully regards discipline, But he who abandons reproof goes astray.
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}

	10:18 (Translation) Lying lips conceal hatred, And the one who airs a rumor—he is a fool.
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This proverb is, it seems to me, particularly important to remember in the age of the internet and of social media. Distortions spread through word of mouth are tremendously damaging. Statements and stories should be read and verified before being passed on.

	10:19 (Translation) Where there are many words, transgression does not cease, While the one who retrains his lips is skillful.
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“Guarded, measured, almost reluctant to open are the ‘lips’ of the truly ‘wise.’ An unchecked flow of words gives opportunity for misleading information, thoughtless advice, or just plain personal hurt” (Hubbard 215).

	10:20 (Translation) The tongue of the righteous is [like] the [very] best silver; The mind of the wicked is worth little.
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“Words from a godly person are valuable... A little good advice has more value than a lot of bad advice. It is easy to get opinions from people who will only tell us what they think will please us, but such counsel does not really help. Instead, we should look for those who speak the truth to us, even when it hurts” (Barton et al. 1032).

	10:21 (Translation) The lips of the righteous shepherd many, But fools die in their lack of sense.
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	10:22 (Translation) The blessing of Yahweh—that is what enriches; And it does not increase toil with it.
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	10:23 (Translation) Enacting schemes is like laughter to a fool, But wisdom is with a man of discernment.
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	10:24 (Translation) The very thing the wicked fears will come upon him, But the desire of the righteous will be granted.
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	10:25 (Translation)
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	When the storm passes by, the wicked are no more; But the righteous has an enduring hiding place.
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}

	10:26 (Translation) Like vinegar to the teeth or smoke to the eyes, So is the lazy man to the one who sends him.
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}

	10:27 (Translation) The fear of Yahweh increases days, While the years of the wicked are cut short.
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	10:28 (Translation) The hope of the righteous is joy, But the anchor of the wicked vanishes.
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	10:29 (Translation) The way of Yahweh is a refuge for the one with integrity, But [it is] destruction to evildoers.
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}

	10:30 (Translation) The righteous will never be moved, And the wicked will not inherit the earth.
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	10:31 (Translation) The mouth of the righteous bears wisdom as its fruit, But a wicked tongue will be destroyed.
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	10:32 (Translation) The lips of the righteous pour forth what is pleasing, While the mouth of the wicked [pours forth] perversity.
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	11:1 (Translation) Deceitful scales are an abomination to Yahweh, While a whole stone is his delight.
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“The Law (Lev. 19:35f.), the Prophets (Mic. 6:10f) and the Wisdom Writings (see also 20:10, 23) agree in

condemning dishonesty primarily for *God's* sake. For the same reason we are encouraged to give not only in full but to overflowing (Luke 6:35, 38)” (Kidner 85). Cheating man is cheating God who made man (cf. Job 31:15).

	11:2 (Translation) Presumption came, and then dishonor came; But with the humble is wisdom.
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	11:3 (Translation) The integrity of the upright guides them, But the crookedness of the treacherous will destroy them.
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	11:4 (Translation) Riches will be of no help in the day of wrath, But righteousness delivers from death.
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{ Readers need to know “riches cannot bribe or buy their possessors out of the grip of God’s ‘*wrath*’ when judgment is their due. Righteousness is their only rescue or ransom. We say, mindlessly mouthing the conventional wisdom, ‘the good die young.’ The Hebrew sages read life the other way around: the righteous may be snatched (delivered) from the jaws of death, but the wicked, no matter no rich, may face God’s wrath and have their loves shortened” (Hubbard, 297).

	11:5 (Translation) The righteousness of those with integrity makes their paths straight, While the wicked will fall in his wickedness.
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}

	11:6 (Translation) The righteousness of the upright will deliver them, While the treacherous will be captured by their own evil desires.
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	11:7 (Translation) At the death of wicked man [his] hope vanishes; Indeed, the hope [even] of mighty men vanishes.
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}

	11:8 (Translation) The righteous man will be snatched away from trouble; And then the wicked man steps into his place.
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	11:9 (Translation) The profane man destroys his neighbor with [his] mouth, While the righteous are delivered by [their] knowledge.
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	11:10 (Translation) At the well-being of the righteous, the city rejoices, And when the wicked vanish, there is a shout [of joy].
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	11:11 (Translation) At the blessing of the upright a city is exalted, But at the mouth of the wicked it is broken down.
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	11:12 (Translation) He who scorns his neighbor lacks sense, For a discerning man keeps silent.
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“The most misleading way to feel wise is to feel superior (14:21 goes further: it is sin), for one is denying that God is the only competent judge of human worth” (Kidner 86).

	11:13 (Translation) The slanderer reveals a secret, But the one who is faithful in spirit conceals a matter.
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	11:14 (Translation) Where there is no consultation, a people falls, And success is with a multitude of advisers.
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“One person's perspective and understanding is severely limited. He or she may not have all the facts or may be blinded by bias, emotion, or wrong impressions.... [S]eek the counsel of others and be open to their advice” (Barton et al. 1034).

	11:15 (Translation) The one who enters a financially binding arrangement with a stranger {with an evil person?} suffers great harm, But the one who hates to strike a bargain is safe.
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11:16 (Paraphrase) Here's the sad reality: Society elevates women who are attractive and men who are aggressive.	11:16 (Translation) A graceful woman will take hold of honor, And oppressive men will take hold of wealth.
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Living in a sinful world requires clear-eyed realism. Throughout history and right down to the present day society has constantly turned its camera lens on women not because of their accomplishments or their character, but for the superficial fact that they exhibit traits that that society deems visually attractive; and men, for their part, tend to be elevated to the top of the social ladder not because they exhibit humility or kindness, but because they are assertive, energetic, and self-promoting—even at the expense of family, friends, and coworkers. Christians should be careful not to fixate on what the world fixates on, or to assume that the lack of acclaim equates to a lack of value.

{Additional Note: the first line could be translated quite differently: {} }

11:17 (Paraphrase) Hand out kindness to your neighbors, and you'll find it knocking at your own door; but cruelty to others is ultimately cruelty to yourself.	11:17 (Translation) A man of loyal kindness benefits himself, But a cruel man harms his own body.
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On the first line, cf. Eph 5: {}

	11:18-19 (Translation) A wicked man effects a deceitful reward, But the one who sows righteousness [effects] a true wage. 19 Thus righteousness leads to life, While the one who pursues evil goes to his [own] death.
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	11:20 (Translation) Perversions of heart are an abomination to Yahweh, But those whose way is integrity are his delight.
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11:21 (Paraphrase) You can count on it:	11:21 (Translation) Hand to hand, the evil will not be held innocent [in the end], But the seed of the righteous will escape.
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	11:22 (Translation) A gold ring in a pig's nose— [Thus is] a woman who is beautiful but lacking in discretion.
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	11:23 (Translation) The desire of the righteous is only good, But the hope of the wicked is wrath.
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11:24 (Paraphrase) The one who gives gains; the one who holds loses. A penny saved may be a penny squandered. ¹¹	11:24 (Translation) There is a kind of person who scatters his possessions and yet gains even more, But the person who withholds what is rightfully due does so only to his lack.
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	11:25 (Translation) A generous soul will be made fat, And he who waters will himself be watered.
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}

	11:26 (Translation) He who withholds grain, the people curse him, But blessing is upon the head of him who distributes food.
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	11:27 (Translation) He who searches for [the common] good seeks goodwill, But the one who pursues evil—it will come upon him!
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}

	11:28 (Translation) The one who trusts in his riches—he will fall, But the righteous will bloom like a leaf on a tree.
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}

	11:29 (Translation) He who troubles his [own] house will inherit [only] wind, And the fool will serve the wise in heart.
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	11:30 (Translation) The fruit of the righteous is a tree of life, But he who destroys lives has engaged in wicked violence.
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¹¹ This paraphrase comes from Hubbard (166), who further remarks, “The Lord did not learn mathematics from *Poor Richard’s Almanac*.”

	11:31 (Translation) If those righteous on earth are recompensed, How much more [will] the wicked and the sinner [be recompensed]!
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12:1 (Paraphrase) “If you don't want to learn, years of schooling will teach you very little. But if you want to be taught, there is no end to what you can learn” (Barton et al. 1035).	12:1 (Translation) He who loves discipline loves knowledge, While he who hates reproach is foolish.
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“No amount of graciousness, patience, or artistry in our teaching will work without deliberate concentration on the part of the hearers. the sages minced no words. Failure to keep open ears was a badge of stupidity” (Hubbard, 281).

	12:2 (Translation) Pursuing [the public] good brings [a] goodwill [that is] from Yahweh, But a man of schemes he holds guilty.
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	12:3 (Translation) A man will not be established by wickedness, But the root of the righteous will not be moved.
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	12:4 (Translation) A woman of excellence is the crown of her husband, While a woman who brings him shame is like decay in his bones.
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	12:5 (Translation) Justice is [the aim of] the plans of the righteous; Deceit is [the aim of] the consultations of the wicked.
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	12:6 (Translation) The words of the wicked are [all about] lying in wait for [the] blood [of innocent victims], But the mouth of the upright delivers them.
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	12:7 (Translation) The wicked are overthrown and are no longer around,
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	But the house of the righteous stands forever.
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}

12:8 (Paraphrase) Prudence produces good publicity, while sin summons public scorn.	12:8 (Translation) A man will be praised in accordance with his prudence, While a perverted mind will be scorned.
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}

Of course, public perceptions aren't everything, which might be why the following proverb (12:9) is something of a counterpoint. Still, where it is possible, you should seek a good public name (cf. Lk 2:52, Ac 24:16, 1 Tim 3:7), and you can expect this name only when your conduct is circumspect.

	12:9 (Translation) Better to be a man who is not well-regarded yet has a servant Than a man who is held in honor yet lacks sense.
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}

	12:10 (Translation) The righteous man is intimately acquainted with the life of his animal, But [even] the “compassion” of the wicked is cruel.
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“Our particular human role is to represent the Creator in the care of the creation (Gen. 1:28). The animal world... is a good place to start. Animal abuse is as unchristian as animal worship or obsession with pets” (Hubbard, 190).

	12:11 (Translation) The one who works his land will have food, But the one who chases after futile ventures lacks sense.
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}

12:12 (Paraphrase) Wicked people get excited about ways to entrap and defeat other people. Righteous people seek to promote well-being and success in others.	12:12 (Translation) A wicked man envies the wicked traps of evil men, But the root of the righteous gives [benefits to others].
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}

	12:13 (Translation) In wicked lips there is an evil trap, But the righteous escapes from trouble.
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}

12:14 (Paraphrase) A man who uses his speech for good purposes can	12:14 (Translation) From the fruit of the mouth of a man he will be
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expect good things in his life, since Yahweh returns to people according to the measure of their actions.	satisfied with good, For the recompense of the hands of man he will give to him.
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{ }

12:15 (Paraphrase) The fool thinks he is never wrong, ¹² but the wise man is willing to listen to correction.	12:15 (Translation) The way of the fool is upright in his eyes, But the one who listens to counsel is wise.
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“We show ourselves men of reason when we *listen*... to reason, and test ourselves for prejudice. The person who always knows best may be the only one unconscious of his real name” (Kidner 92).

	12:16 (Translation) The fool makes his indignation known on the [same] day [as the offense], But the one who conceals dishonor is shrewd.
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{ }

	12:17 (Translation) He who testifies faithfully speaks righteousness, And a witness of lies is treachery.
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{ }

	12:18 (Translation) There is a kind of man who speaks rashly like a sword piercing [flesh], But the tongue of the wise heals.
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{ }

	12:19 (Translation) Truthful lips will be established forever, But lying lips are [only] momentary.
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{ }

	12:20 (Translation) Treachery is in the heart of those who devise evil, But for those who counsel peace there is joy.
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“[T]he two halves of the proverb make the point that what we pursue for others, and the way we pursue it, leaves its mark on the cast of our mind” (Kidner 93).

	12:21 (Translation) No trouble shall befall the righteous, But the [lives of the] wicked are full of disaster.
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“This is another general but not universal principle. Although harm and misfortune do come to godly people, these people are able to find opportunities in their problems and move ahead. The wicked, without God's

¹² Kidner's catchphrase for this verse is the ironic **The man who is never wrong** (92).

wisdom, are ill-equipped to handle their problems” (Barton et al. 1037).

	12:22 (Translation) Lying lips are an abomination to Yahweh, But those who act in faithfulness are his delight.
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}

12:23 (Paraphrase) A shrewd man keeps his cards close to his chest. The fool triumphantly shows everyone his losing hand.	12:23 (Translation) A shrewd man conceals knowledge, But the mind of the fool shouts out foolishness.
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}

	12:24 (Translation) The diligent hand shall rule, While the lazy man will be put to forced labor.
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}

	12:25 (Translation) Anxiety in a man's heart pushes it down, But good news gives it joy.
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}

	12:26 (Translation) The righteous points out the right road to his neighbor, While the way of the wicked causes them to go astray.
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}

12:27 (Paraphrase) “Diligent people make wise use of their possessions and resources; lazy people waste them” (Barton et al. 1037).	12:27 (Translation) The lazy man does not [even] roast his meat, But the treasure of man is precious and refined.
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Laziness does not properly handle even what little it has, which is a shame since there is in fact real beauty and value to be had.

	12:28 (Translation) In the righteous way is life, And its road leads to immortality.
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}

	13:1 (Translation) A wise son [listens] to his father's discipline, But a scoffer does not listen to rebuke.
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}

	13:2 (Translation)
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	From the fruit of the mouth of a man he will eat good things, But the soul of the treacherous is wicked.
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{}

	13:3 (Translation) He who guards his mouth guards his soul; The one who parts his lips—ruin is his!
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{}

	13:4 (Translation) The lazy man longs [for things] but has nothing, But the soul of the diligent will be made fat.
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{}

	13:5 (Translation) A righteous man hates a deceitful matter, But a wicked man brings shame and dishonor.
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13:6 (Paraphrase) The upright life is self-consistent, while the ungodly life works at cross-purposes even with itself.	13:6 (Translation) Righteousness keeps the way of integrity, While wickedness acts perverts sin.
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Ultimately, all sin is irrational, self-defeating, and bizarre. True discretion, consistency, and harmony is to be found by ordering one's life by God's principles.

	13:7 (Translation) There is a kind of man who puts on the airs of a rich man yet has absolutely nothing; [There is also] a kind of man who acts like a poor man yet has great wealth.
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{?...has nothing to lose}	13:8 (Translation) The redemption of a man's life is his wealth, Yet a poor man does not listen to a rebuke.
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{}

	13:9 (Translation) The light of the righteous will rejoice, But the lamp of the wicked will go out.
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{}

	13:10 (Translation) With presumptuousness comes strife,
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	But those who receive counsel there is wisdom.
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{}

13:11 (Paraphrase) Haste makes waste; {}	13:11 (Translation) Wealth hastily gained quickly shrinks, But he who gathers by hand increases [his holdings].
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{}

	13:12 (Translation) Hope long drawn out marks a heart sick, But a met desire is a tree of life.
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{ “One of the greatest gifts of the gospel is its hope which never lets us down (Rom. 5:5)” (Hubbard, 197).

13:13 (Paraphrase) Ignorance of the law is no excuse; but following orders leads to promotion.	13:13 (Translation) He who scorns God’s Word will [nonetheless] be held liable for its demands, But the one who respects a commandment—he will be recompensed.
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Additional Note

The Hebrew (דבר) translated “God’s Word” might above mean instead “a directive,” in which case the proverb is more general. But even if so (in defense of the rendering given above, cf. 16:20 and Ps 56:10), the general principle given in the proverb would apply to the Bible above all.

	13:14 (Translation) The instruction of a wise man is a life-giving fountain Which turns [people] away from death's snares.
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	13:15 (Translation) Good sense grants favor, But the way of the treacherous is hard.
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{Cf. 1 Pet 3:13}

	13:16 (Translation) Every shrewd man acts on the basis of knowledge, While a fool puts foolishness on display.
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“As we seek to know God's will, we must gather all the facts we can and assess them, because our decisions must be based on knowledge and not hearsay” (Wiersbe 171).

	13:17 (Translation) A wicked messenger will fall into calamity, But a faithful messenger [will find] healing.
--	--

“Accurate information is essential to the sound decisions that the wise teachers valued. Our judgments can rarely

be better than our grasp of the facts” (Hubbard, 178).

	13:18 (Translation) Poverty and dishonor let go of discipline, While the one who pays close attention to reproof will receive honor.
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	13:19 (Translation) A desire realized is sweet to the soul, Yet turning from evil is an abomination to fools.
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13:20 (Paraphrase) Be careful who your friends are, for their character will rub off on you, and their fate will be yours as well.	13:20 (Translation) Walk with the wise, and be wise, For the friend of fools will come to ruin.
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13:21 (Paraphrase) Sinners can expect trouble, but God is known for rewarding the righteous.	13:21 (Translation) Disaster chases after sinners, But he will recompense the righteous with good things.
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{cf. Heb 11:6?}

	13:22 (Translation) Goodness provides an inheritance to grandchildren, And the wealth of the sinner is stored up for [the benefit of] the righteous.
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	13:23 (Translation) Litigation devours the poor man’s farm land, ¹³ And there is such a man as is swept away unjustly.
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“Injustice was not a trivial deviation from society’s norm [in agrarian ancient Israel] but a matter of life and death, especially for the poor, and more specially where food supply was the issue” (Hubbard, 346). Wrongdoing harms those with the least ability to absorb setbacks.

	13:24 (Translation) He who withholds his rod hates his son, But he who loves him is diligent in the matter of discipline.
--	---

“What a tragedy when children are left to themselves, not knowing where or what the boundaries are and what the consequences of rebellion will be! I may be wrong, but I have a suspicion that many people who can’t discipline their children have a hard time disciplining themselves.” (Wiersbe 125).

¹³ This line I borrow from Scott (94).

“This verse (and others like it, e.g. 22:15; 23:13-14; 29:15, 17) receive bad press among many Western Christians who are hesitant about corporal punishment in the light of community concerns about child abuse. The focus [here] is on the value of discipline more than it is on the means used (in ancient Israel, corporal punishment, the rod). The lesson being taught is much wider. Children or youths who are left to follow their own desires will usually be self-indulgent rather than self-disciplined. Echoing verse 1, we all need discipline to become the people God wants us to be, and this takes effort (e.g. 2 Pet. 1:5-8). The proper exercise of discipline is not an abuse of power, but rather an outworking of loving concern for those entrusted to our care” (Wilson 173).

	13:25 (Translation) The righteous eats until his appetite is satisfied, But the belly of the wicked lacks [sufficient nutriment].
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	14:1 (Translation) The wisdom of women builds her house, But the foolish woman tears it down with her own hands.
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	14:2 (Translation) He who walks in his uprightness fears Yahweh, While the one who turns away from his ways despises him.
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“The 'despising' may be unconscious, but none the less real. Every departure from God's path is a pitting of one's will, and a backing of one's [own] judgment, against his; but the contempt which it spells is too irrational to acknowledge” (Kidner 100).

	14:3 (Translation) In the mouth of fools is a branch of pride, But the lips of the wise guard them.
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	14:4 (Translation) Where there are no oxen, the manger is clean, But great income is in the strength of the bull.
--	--

	14:5 (Translation) A faithful witness will not lie, While a lying witness is a false witness.
--	--

	14:6 (Translation) The scoffer has sought wisdom yet found nothing, Yet knowledge comes easily to the man of discernment.
--	--

	14:7 (Translation) Leave the presence of a fool, For [otherwise] you will not experience knowledgeable lips.
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	14:8 (Translation) The wisdom of the shrewd give him insight for his way, But the foolishness of fools is treachery.
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	14:9 (Translation) Fools scoff at shame, But among the upright is [mutual] goodwill. {or, “is favor”?}
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	14:10 (Translation) The heart [alone] knows the bitterness of its soul, And in its joy no stranger [truly] participates.
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	14:11 (Translation) The house of the wicked will be destroyed, But the tent of the upright will flourish.
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	14:12 (Translation) There is a way that is [seemingly] upright before a man, Yet its end is the path to death.
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	14:13 (Translation) Even during laughter a heart can be grieving, And the sequel to happiness is grief.
--	--

“The teachers know that emotions may be mixed, that we may not be able to discern all that we feel because feelings swirl within us in complex patterns” (Hubbard, 321).

14:14 (Paraphrase) Some people find their sense of purpose fulfilled by living wickedly, others by living well.	14:14 (Translation) A deviant heart is satisfied with its ways, And a good man [is satisfied] with its deeds.
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	14:15 (Translation) The naive man believes everything he hears, But the shrewd man looks discerningly to his steps.
--	--

	14:16 (Translation) The wise man is fearful and turns from evil,
--	--

	But the fool is arrogant and [self-]confident.
	14:17 (Translation) A short temper accomplishes foolishness, And a man who involves himself in plots will be hated.
	14:18 (Translation) The naive inherit [only] foolishness, But the shrewd have knowledge for a crown.
14:19 (Paraphrase) [Do not lose heart, for]	14:19 (Translation) Evil men have been known to bow down before good men, And wicked men [have been known to bow down] at the gates of the righteous.
	14:20 (Translation) A poor man is hated even by his neighbor, But a rich man is loved by many.
	14:21 (Translation) A sinner is scorned by his neighbor, But the one who lends to the poor—how blessed is he!
	14:22 (Translation) Will not those who plan evil wander? But grace and truth are [what fall to] those who plan good.
14:23 (Paraphrase) Blood, sweat, and tears: Something. Talk, talk, and more talk: Nothing.	14:23 (Translation) With every toil there be a surplus, But the word on the lips leads only to lack.
“Some people are needy because they <i>like to talk but never act</i> ” (Wiersbe 107).	
	14:24 (Translation) The crown of the wise is their wealth; The folly of fools in foolishness.
	14:25 (Translation) A faithful witness saves lives, But a deceitful witness is treachery.
	14:26 (Translation)

	In the fear of Yahweh is a strong source of confidence, And his children will [always] have a refuge.
	14:27 (Translation) The fear of Yahweh is a spring of life, Turning one away from death's snares.
	14:28 (Translation) In the multitude of people is a king's majesty, And in the small number of a people is a ruler's destruction.
	14:29 (Translation) Being slow to anger is an abundance of discernment, While being short-tempered exalts folly.
	14:30 (Translation) A healing heart is life to the body, While jealousy is decay in the bones.
	14:31 (Translation) He who oppresses the poor taunts his maker, While he who honors him lends to the needy.
	14:32 (Translation) The wicked man will be crushed in his [own] evil, While the righteous man takes refuge in his integrity.
	14:33 (Translation) Wisdom takes up residence in the heart of the discerning, But in the midst of fools it is unknown.
	14:34 (Translation) Righteousness exalts a nation, But sin is the reproach of a people.
	14:35 (Translation) The king's goodwill belongs to the servant who is prudent, While his wrath is for the one who brings him shame.
15:1 (Paraphrase) To keep from war while in a spat,	15:1 (Translation) A soft answer turns away anger,

Turn down your anger thermostat. ¹⁴	While a harsh word stirs up anger.
{ }	15:2 (Translation) The tongue of the wise excels in knowledge, While the mouth of fools pours forth foolishness.
The wise have something substantive to say, but not so the wicked: “One of my schoolteachers used to say, 'Empty barrels make the most noise,' and she was right. Too often... those who talk the most have the least to say” (Wiersbe 144).	
	15:3 (Translation) The eyes of Yahweh are in every place, Keeping watch on the evil and the good.
15:4 (Paraphrase) { }	15:4 (Translation) A healing tongue is a tree of life, While perversion in it is brokenness in spirit.
{ } “A word of encouragement can make the difference between [someone] giving up or going on.” ¹⁵	
	15:5 (Translation) The fool treats his father's discipline with contempt, But the one who pays careful attention to reproof acts shrewdly.
	15:6 (Translation) Great treasure is in the house of the righteous, While the income of the wicked sees trouble.
	15:7 (Translation) The lips of the wise scatter knowledge, But the heart of the fools is not like that.
	15:8 (Translation) A sacrifice from the wicked is an abomination to Yahweh, But the prayer of the upright is his delight.
	15:9 (Translation) The evil way is an abomination to Yahweh, But he loves the one who pursues righteousness.
15:10 (Paraphrase) If someone sees someone going down the wrong	15:10 (Translation) The correction of a neighbor is [helpful and

¹⁴ This aphorism is taken from Shorey, 225.

¹⁵ I read this somewhere, I think in a copy of the *Our Daily Bread* devotional.

street, it is only right to shout out a warning. The person who refuses to listen to such correctives is in for a world of hurt.	appropriate] for the one who leaves the path; He who hates reproof will die.
--	---

Cf. 12:26

	15:11 (Translation) Sheol and Abaddon are before Yahweh— How much more the hearts of the sons of Adam!
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(Rev reference to Abaddon)

	15:12 (Translation) The scoffer does not love it when he is reproved; He will not go to the wise.
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	15:13 (Translation) A joyful heart lights up the face, But pain of heart means a broken spirit.
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	15:14 (Translation) A discerning heart seeks out knowledge, While the mouth of fools feeds on folly.
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“[T]hose who know most know best how little they know” (Kidner 122); stated negatively, as I’ve heard it said, “Those who talk the loudest know the least.” We need to be learners.

	15:15 (Translation) All the days of the afflicted are bad, But a good heart is a continual feast.
--	--

	15:16 (Translation) A little good with the fear of Yahweh Is better than a vast treasury and tumult with it.
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15:17 (Paraphrase) A bowl of vegetables with some you love is better than steak with someone you hate (NLT).	15:17 (Translation) A meal of vegetables with love at the table Is better than a fattened calf and hatred with it.
--	---

15:18 (Paraphrase) “Staying calm is the best way to take the wind out of an angry person's sails.” ¹⁶	15:18 (Translation) An angry man stirs up strife, But a patient man quiets a dispute.
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15:19 (Paraphrase) Being lazy is like fighting your way through thick	15:19 (Translation) The lazy man's road is like a briar hedge, But the path of the upright is elevated.
--	--

¹⁶ I read this somewhere, I think in a copy of the *Our Daily Bread* devotional.

underbrush of a forest, when with a bit of diligence you could have used a footbridge.	
--	--

It might sound like a contradiction, but in the end, it's easier to work hard than to be lazy.

	15:20 (Translation) A wise son makes his father happy, While a foolish man scorns his mother.
--	--

	15:21 (Translation) Foolishness is joy for those who lack sense, But a man of discernment goes straight on.
--	--

	15:22 (Translation) Plans fall apart where there is no counsel, But with a multiple of counselors they are established.
--	--

	15:23 (Translation) There is joy for a man in the answer of the mouth, And a word in its time—how good it is!
--	--

	15:24 (Translation) The way of life goes upward for the prudent So that he can turn aside from Sheol below.
--	--

	15:25 (Translation) Yahweh will snatch away the house of the proud, And he will establish the border of the widow[’s property].
--	--

	15:26 (Translation) Wicked plans are an abomination to Yahweh, And pleasant words are pure.
--	--

	15:27 (Translation) He who engages in robbery troubles his [own] house, But he who hates bribes will live.
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	15:28 (Translation) The righteous mind ponders how to answer, But the mouth of the wicked pours forth evil things.
--	---

	15:29 (Translation) Yahweh is far from the wicked, But he hears the prayer of the righteous.
--	---

	15:30 (Translation) The light of the eyes makes the heart happy; A good report makes the bones grow fat.
--	---

	15:31 (Translation) The ear that listens to reproof is life[-giving]; In the midst of the wise it will dwell.
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	15:32 (Translation) He who lets go of discipline rejects his [own] life, But he who listens to reproof [thereby] acquires a[n intelligent] mind.
--	---

	15:33 (Translation) The fear of Yahweh is the discipline that wisdom brings, And before honor [comes] humility.
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	16:1 (Translation) The mind's plans belong to man, But the answer of the tongue is from Yahweh.
--	--

“God expects us to use our brains and make plans, but He also expects us to submit those plans to Him and to let Him make the final decision” (Wiersbe 171).

	16:2 (Translation) All the ways of a man are pure in his [own] eyes, But the one who establishes spirits is Yahweh.
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	16:3 (Translation) Roll your works over to Yahweh, And he will establish your plans.
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	16:4 (Translation) God has made everything for its purpose, Even the wicked for the day of judgment.
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{cf. Rom 9:16-18}

	16:5 (Translation) Every lofty mind is an abomination to Yahweh; Hand to hand, it will not be held guiltless.
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	16:6 (Translation) In grace and truth iniquity is atoned for,
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	And in the fear of Yahweh is turning from evil.
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“‘Fear of the Lord’—like the four notes that mark of the theme of Beethoven’s Fifth Symphony, these words are pounded out at the beginning of Proverbs (1:9), the end of the wisdom speeches (9:10), and periodically through the rest of the book. Its repetition never lets us forget the theological and spiritual meaning of wisdom. Its recurrence means that we can never slip into a secular definitions of insight or prudence; we can never view wisdom as mere cunning or skill. ‘Fear of the Lord,’ sprinkled as it is throughout the text, salts the whole collection and preserves with from becoming tainted with flatly humanistic or plainly pragmatic approaches to wisdom” (Hubbard 198).	
	16:7 (Translation) In the favor of Yahweh are the ways of a man; Even his enemies he brings into a state of peace with him.
	16:8 (Translation) It is better to have little with righteousness Than great income without justice.
	16:9 (Translation) The mind of a man plans his way, But Yahweh establishes his steps.
	16:10 (Translation) Divination on the lips of a king— Justice he must not violate with his mouth!
	16:11 (Translation) The balance and scales of justice belong to Yahweh; All stones for weight are his work.
	16:12 (Translation) An abomination of kings is acting wickedly, For in righteousness a throne will be established.
	16:13 (Translation) The delight of kings is righteous speech, And the one who speaks upright things will be loved.
	16:14 (Translation) The wrath of a king is messengers of death, But a wise man covers it over.
	16:15 (Translation)

	In the king's smile is life, And his delight is like the cloud that brings a spring rain.
--	--

	16:16 (Translation) How good it is to acquire wisdom! And the acquisition of discernment is to be desired more than silver.
--	--

	16:17 (Translation) The highway of the upright is turning away from evil; He who keeps his way guards his soul.
--	--

	16:18 (Translation) Before breakage comes pride, And before a fall [comes] a lofty spirit.
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	16:19 (Translation) Better is a lowly spirit among the humble Than dividing the spoil [of war] with the proud.
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“The mention of the proud enjoying (temporary) plunder and the seemingly righteous poor indicates that Proverbs itself realizes that the wise do not prosper all the time, nor are the wicked punished without exception. Temporary suffering and prosperity can also be observed” (Wilson 199). We must take the long view, and accumulate treasures in heaven rather than on earth (Mat 5:19ff).

16:20 (Paraphrase) Be a good worker... who correctly explains the word of truth... if we endure hardship, we will reign with him (2 Tim 2:15, 12, NLT)	16:20 (Translation) He who is prudent with regard to the Word finds a good thing, And he who trusts in Yahweh—how happy is he!
--	---

	16:21 (Translation) The wise mind will be called discerning, And sweet lips will increase persuasiveness.
--	--

“What we say must make sense... And how we say it is also vital to getting the point across... It is the spoonful of sugar that helps the medicine go down” (Hubbard 222).

	16:22 (Translation) A fountain of life is prudence to him who has mastered it, And the “discipline” of fools is foolishness.
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}

	16:23 (Translation) A wise mind teaches its mouth skill, And increases learning on its mouth.
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A big part of being wise is communicating with others in a clear and kind way.

	16:24 (Translation) {}
	16:25 (Translation) There is a way that is upright before a man, Yet its ends is the path to death.
	16:26 (Translation) The hunger of a laborer labors for him, For his mouth impels him.
	16:27 (Translation) A {} plots evil, And on his lips it is like a burning fire.
	16:28 (Translation) A perverse man shoots off strife, And who whispers dissension separates friends.
	16:29 (Translation) A {} man fools his neighbor, And leads him on a path which is not good.
	16:30 (Translation) A person winks with his eyes to plot perversity; He who purses his lips has accomplished evil.
16:31 (Paraphrase) “To avoid the mistakes of youth, draw from the wisdom of age.” ¹⁷ {} 	16:31 (Translation) Gray hair is a crown of beauty; It is found in the way of righteousness.
16:32 (Paraphrase) “In the sight of God no conquest is so important as the victory over self!” ¹⁸ {} 	16:32 (Translation) It is better to be a patient man than a warrior, And [it is better to be] someone with self-control than someone who conquers a city.
16:33 (Paraphrase) Roll a dice, but realize that God has ordained the	16:33 (Translation) The lots falls in the lap,

¹⁷ I read this somewhere, I think in a copy of the *Our Daily Bread* devotional.

¹⁸ I read this somewhere, I think in a copy of the *Our Daily Bread* devotional.

outcome.	But its every decision is from Yahweh.
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There is no such thing as luck. Even randomness is under divine direction. The sooner we realize that God is in complete control of absolutely everything, the better off we will be. “God's plans included you. Do your plans include God?”¹⁹

17:1 (Paraphrase) “It's not your position that makes you happy, It's your disposition.” ²⁰	17:1 (Translation) Better is a dry crumb and quietness with it Than a house full of contentious feasts.
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?Movie “The Greatest Gift”

	17:2 (Translation) A prudent servant will rule over a son who brings shame, And he will have a share among the brothers.
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“Privilege, as an obstacle or a support, looms larger in most people's minds than in God's, in things both spiritual (Amos 9:7; Matt. 8:11, 12) and temporal. Solomon's proverb was to be strikingly borne out in the careers of his servant and his son (1 Kgs 11:28ff.)” (Kidner 116).

	17:3 (Translation) A crucible is for silver, and a furnace is for gold, But the one who tests hearts is Yahweh.
--	--

	17:4 (Translation) The evildoer listens to wicked lips; The deceiver listens to a destructive tongue.
--	--

	17:5 (Translation) He who mocks the poor taunts his maker; Happiness in the face of calamity will not be held guiltless.
--	---

	17:6 (Translation) The crown of old men is grandchildren, And the crown of sons is their fathers.
--	--

	17:7 (Translation) Excessive speech is not fitting for a fool; How much less [is] deceitful speech [fitting] for a nobleman!
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	17:8 (Translation) A bribe is a gem in the eyes of its master;
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¹⁹ I read this somewhere, I think in a copy of the *Our Daily Bread* devotional.

²⁰ I read this somewhere, I think in a copy of the *Our Daily Bread* devotional.

	Wherever he turns, he prospers.
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	17:9 (Translation) He who conceals a transgression seeks love, While he who repeats a matter separates friends.
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“Silence is never more golden than when we refuse to make personal capital by gossiping about the failings of a friend” (Hubbard 262).

	17:10 (Translation) A rebuke sinks into a discerning man More than a hundred blows [sink into] a fool.
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	17:11 (Translation) Only a rebel seeks evil, And a cruel messenger is sent by him.
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	17:12 (Translation) Better a bear bereaved of her cubs meeting a man, Than a fool in his folly.
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	17:13 (Translation) He who returns evil for good— Evil will not depart from his house.
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17:14 (Paraphrase) The beginning of a feud is like the breaking of a dam, so find a way to put the offense behind you before you get swept away by the floodwaters of a broken relationship!	17:14 (Translation) The beginning of strife is [like] the release of water, So before the dispute breaks out—let go [of your intent to press matters]!
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	17:15 (Translation) He who acquits the wicked and he who condemns the righteous— Both are an abomination to Yahweh.
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17:16 (Paraphrase) Wisdom can't be bought, and the attempt to buy it only shows its absence.	17:16 (Translation) Why is there money in the hand of a fool To purchase wisdom when he lacks sense?
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Cf. (from Ac) trying to buy the Holy Spirit

	17:17 (Translation) A friend loves at all times, And a brother is born for adversity.
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“[I]n trouble you see what family ties are for, and you also see who are your friends” (Kidner 118).

17:18 (Paraphrase)	17:18 (Translation) A man lacking in sense clasps the hand, Giving a pledge in the presence of a neighbor.
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	17:19 (Translation) He who loves transgression loves contention; He who makes his door high seeks brokenness.
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17:20 (Paraphrase) {}	17:20 (Translation) The twisted heart will not find any good, And he who is perverted in his tongue will fall into evil.
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(Wordplay evil = calamity) {}

{}	17:21 (Translation) He who begets a fool—what grief is his! Nor will the father of a fool rejoice.
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{}

{}	17:22 (Translation) A joyful heart is good at [self-]healing, But a broken spirit dries up one's self.
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{}

{}	17:23 (Translation) A bribe is secretly received from a wicked man In order to subvert the ways of justice.
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“Bribery... undermines the foundations of society. Bribery necessarily favors the haves against the have-nots because only the affluent can afford it. If ‘*the ways of justice*’ are put to action, the poor will always be outbid” (Hubbard, 310). Fairness to the poor in the courtroom is one of the first laws of Moses (Ex 23:6).

17:24 (Paraphrase) The foolish man thinks he needs to journey the far side of the world to obtain wisdom, but in fact it is not so far away: Just get to know a discerning individual.	17:24 (Translation) In the presence of a discerning man is wisdom, But the eyes of the fools are on the ends of the earth.
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	17:25 (Translation) A foolish son vexes his father, And embitters the one who bore him.
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	17:26 (Translation) Assuredly, it is not good to impose a[n illegitimate] fine on the righteous,
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	Punishing noble men on [their] uprightness.
	17:27 (Translation) The one who restrains his words exhibits knowledge, And the one who is calm of spirit is a man of discernment.
17:28 (Paraphrase) Better to remain silent and be thought a fool than to speak and remove all doubt. ²¹ {	17:28 (Translation) Even a fool will be thought wise when he keeps silent; The one who closes his lips is discerning.
18:1 (Paraphrase) {	18:1 (Translation) A self-isolating man seeks a pretense; He disdains every opportunity for a positive outcome.
	18:2 (Translation) The fool does not delight in discernment, Only in revealing his thoughts.
	18:3 (Translation) When the wicked man comes, shame comes as well, And with infamous behavior comes dishonor.
	18:4 (Translation) The words of a man's mouth are [like] deep waters; The spring of wisdom is [like] a flowing stream.
	18:5 (Translation) Showing bias toward a wicked man is not good, Subverting [the case of] a righteous man in a court of law.
	18:6 (Translation) The lips of a fool enter into disputes, And his mouth calls for conflict.
	18:7 (Translation) The mouth of a fool is his destruction, And his lips are a snare for his soul.
	18:8 (Translation)

²¹ This line is often attributed to Mark Twain, but documentation is lacking.

	The words of one whispering dissension are like delicacies, For they go down [delightfully] into the chambers of the belly.
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	18:9 (Translation) The one who is lazy in his occupation Is the very brother of the destructive man.
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{ } “Laziness, then, however cool and laid-back it may seem, is big-league mayhem” (Hubbard, 156).

	18:10 (Translation) The name of Yahweh is a strong tower: The righteous runs into it and is securely high up.
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	18:11 (Translation) A rich man's wealth is like his fortified city, And like a high wall in his imagination.
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“The world thinks that the unseen is the unreal. But it is not the man of God ([v]10) but the man of property, who must draw on *his imagination...* to feel secure” (Kidner 121). In the end, the power that wealth brings is an illusion. This is a warning to the oppressive rich and a comfort to the oppressed poor.

	18:12 (Translation) Before destruction a heart is lifted up, While before honor is humility.
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	18:13 (Translation) He who answers a matter before he hears it out– It is a folly to him and a { }.
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{ } This surely includes passing along articles online without actually having read them.

	18:14 (Translation) A man's spirit can contain his illness, But a crushed spirit—who can bear that?
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An upbeat spirit goes a long way in getting someone through physical challenges, but depression is “easier to prevent than to cure” (Hubbard 207).

18:15 (Paraphrase) Intelligent people are always ready to learn. Their ears are open to knowledge.	18:15 (Translation) A discerning mind acquires knowledge, And the ear of the wise seeks knowledge.
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Somewhere I heard a riddle with its answer that went something like this: “How do you tell who is the smartest student in the classroom? It's the one who asks the most questions.” One might think that a smart individual has no need for further study, but in fact truly intelligent men and women recognize that their knowledge base is limited and that they stand to benefit from further learning. Not only this, but such people find a certain joy in learning.

The accomplishments of God are unsearchable (Job 9:10), which means that for those who delight to

study his works (Ps 111:2), the joy of discovery will be unending.²²

	18:16 (Translation) A man's bribe opens things up for him, And brings him before powerful men.
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	18:17 (Translation) The first man is [seemingly] correct in his version of the dispute; [Then] the neighbor comes and searches it out.
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18:18 (Paraphrase) Appeal to a neutral decision-making system can forestall conflict.	18:18 (Translation) The lot quiets disputes, And separates warriors.
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In ancient Israel, casting lots (on which see the comments on {}) was apparently at times used to decide how to resolve otherwise intractable disagreements. Perhaps the deeper idea behind this proverb is that an agreed-upon system for resolving disputes is greatly helpful. To an extent a book of church order for a denomination or an employee handbook for a business can fulfill the spirit of this proverb. Of course, this is a proverb, not a promise. Some people will never be satisfied. Also, Christians ought to be willing to be the ones wronged rather than seek redress at all costs (1 Cor 6:7). Still, it is worth looking for a system which will satisfy all parties involved if and when a disagreement arises.

18:19 (Paraphrase) It's easier to capture a castle than to win back the trust of a family member whose feelings you have hurt.	18:19 (Translation) A brother transgressed against is like a strongly fortified city, And strife is like the bars of a citadel.
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{ } Surely in this case the modern proverb is applicable: An ounce of prevention is worth a pound of cure. Or in the words of Paul, we must be “eager to guard the unity of the Spirit in the bond of peace” (Eph 4:3).

	18:20 (Translation) From the fruit of a man's mouth his belly will be satisfied; The income of his lips will satisfy [him].
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	18:21 (Translation) Death and life are in the power of the tongue, And those who love it will eat its fruit.
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“Have you heard the fable of the king and the menu? A king once asked his cook to prepare for him the best dish in the world, and he was served a dish of tongue. The king then asked for the worst dish in the world, and again was served tongue.

‘Why do you serve me the same food as both the best and the worst?’ the perplexed monarch asked.

²² There is a sense in which upon seeing the face of Jesus our knowledge of him will be full (1 Cor 13:12), but this sense is more personal than ideational—we will be secure forever in his love, but the explication of his kindness will be one that unfolds for one epoch after another in the days of eternity (Eph 2:7).

'Because, your majesty,' the cook replied, 'the tongue is the best of things when used wisely and lovingly, but it is the worst of things when used carelessly and unkindly'" (Wiersbe 144).

	18:22 (Translation) He who finds a wife has found something good [indeed], And has obtained favor from Yahweh.
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"The wording, especially in the Heb[rew], strikingly resembles that of 8:35, and so suggests that after wisdom itself, the best of God's [earthly] blessings is a good wife" (Kidner 123).

	18:23 (Translation) The poor man begs and begs, But the rich man answers harshly.
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"Such detached reporting, with its pointed lack of comment, faces the reader with the ugliness of the world his lives in... and reminds him to to take its pains and prizes calmly (cf. Ja[me]s 1:9, 10; 5:6, 7). For an explicit evaluation, see 19:1" (Kidner 123).

18:24 (Paraphrase) Too many cooks spoil the broth, But {}	18:24 (Translation) A man of [many] friends will suffer harm, But there is a friend who sticks closer than a brother.
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NB wordplay ("the man with too many friends will fall"?)

	19:1 (Translation) Better is a poor man living with integrity, Than a man perverted in his lips and a fool.
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19:2 (Paraphrase) Look before you leap.	19:2 (Translation) {Also,} without knowledge a soul is not good, And he who is hasty with his legs sins.
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Culpable ignorance will get you into trouble. There is probably a word play in the second half, for the Hebrew word translated "sins" here could also mean "miss the mark." The person violating this proverb is like a soccer player who has not bothered to learn good strategy and proceeds to kick the ball at the net without setting things up first.

19:3 (Paraphrase) If a person's life is train track, his foolishness is dynamite--yet when the train wreck happens, he blames God!	19:3 (Translation) The folly of a man turns up his way, And his heart rages against Yahweh.
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	19:4 (Translation) Wealth makes many friends, But a poor man is separated from his friend.
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Tom Paine quote?

	19:5 (Translation)
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	A deceptive witness will not be held guiltless, And a lying witness will not escape.
	19:6 (Translation) Many men try to get on a nobleman's good side, And everyone is a friend to the man offering bribes.
	19:7 (Translation) All a poor man's brothers hate him; How much more are his friends separated from him— [Though] he pursues [them with] words, they are not [there to help him].
	19:8 (Translation) He who acquires {} loves his [own] soul; He who pays close attention to discernment has certainly found good.
	19:9 (Translation) A deceptive witness will not be held guiltless, And a lying witness will vanish [from the earth].
	19:10 (Translation) Luxury is not fitting for a fool; How much less for a servant to rule over princes.
19:11 (Paraphrase) The trophies on your shelf should be the times you didn't lose your temper.	19:11 (Translation) The prudence of a person makes him slow to anger, And his glory is passing over transgression. “Constraint of temper gains its highest marks when it is in evidence as a response to attack” (Hubbard 211).
	19:12 (Translation) {} {}
19:13 (Paraphrase) A son making poor choices is like a crumbling rowhome, and a wife who questions every move is like nails on a chalkboard. {}	19:13 (Translation) Destruction comes to the father of a foolish son, And a continuous dripping are the contentions of a[n argumentative] wife.
19:14 (Paraphrase) You can thank your parents and grandparents for generational wealth, but you can only thank God for a	19:14 (Translation) House and wealth come from fathers, But a prudent wife is from Yahweh.

wise wife.	
Those who are happily married ought as they read this verse to breathe out a prayer of thanks to God.	
	19:15 (Translation) Laziness casts a deep sleep, And a slack soul will go hungry.
{wordplay–soul = appetite becoming hungry?}	
	19:16 (Translation) He who keeps the commandment [of God] keeps his life [safe]; He who despises his ways will die.
19:28 (Paraphrase) When you care for a poor person, it is as if you are helping God himself.	19:17 (Translation) He who is gracious to the poor lends to Yahweh, And he who cares for him recompenses him.
Cf. “one of these little ones”	
	19:18 (Translation) Discipline your son while there is hope, And do not let your soul relent on account of his loud cry [of protest].
	19:19 (Translation) He who has a terrible temper must bear the penalty, For if you deliver him, you will only have to do it again.
19:20 (Paraphrase) Take the long view: Cultivate wisdom now, and you'll the benefits later.	19:20 (Translation) Listen to counsel and receive instruction, That you may be wise in your latter days.
Analogy of financial investing?	
	19:21 (Translation) Many are the plans in a man's mind, But Yahweh's counsel—that it was will be established.
	19:22 (Translation) The fruit of a man is his faithful kindness, And a poor man is better than a liar.
	19:23 (Translation) The fear of Yahweh leads to life, And, [his needs] satisfied, he will dwell unhindered by

	evil.
	19:24 (Translation) The lazy man buries his hand in the dish, But will not even return it to his mouth.
19:25 (Paraphrase) Punishment for the intractable can teach a lesson to onlookers who are willing to learn; mere reproof is an effective teaching instrument for those with discernment.	19:25 (Translation) Strike a scoffer and the naive will gain insight, And when a discerning man is reproofed, he will recognize [new] knowledge.
	19:26 (Translation) A destroyer of his father who drives his mother away Is a son who brings shame and dishonor.
	19:27 (Translation) Find good success, my son, in listening to discipline, So that you may swerve away from evil words.
	19:28 (Translation) An evil witness scoffs at justice, And the mouth of the wicked announces iniquity.
Additional Note The second line of v28 contains one of Proverb's numerous puns, not all of which are obvious outside of Hebrew: the verb for "announces" (בלע) can also mean "swallows." The evil man speaks evil with his mouth, but also takes evil into his soul.	
	19:29 (Translation) Rods are prepared for scoffers, And blows for the backs of fools.
	20:1 (Translation) He who mocks wine groans with alcohol; Indeed, no one who gets drunk with it shows wisdom.
	20:2 (Translation) The king's fury is a lion's roar; He who angers him sins against his own life.
	20:3 (Translation) It is honor for a man to live without entering into litigation,

	While every man of iniquity stirs up strife.
20:4 (Paraphrase) No preparation, no production. {explain plowing time}	20:4 (Translation) The lazy man does not plow in autumn; He will ask in the harvest and find nothing.
20:5 (Paraphrase) {}	20:5 (Translation) Deep waters are the counsel in a man's heart, But a man of discernment draws it out.
This “proverb concerns that insight into human nature which Proverbs aims to impart, whereby a discerning person can bring to light the deepest intentions... of another” (Kidner 129). {Examples of this discernment?}	
	20:6 (Translation) Many a man is called kind, But who can find a faithful man?
{}	
	20:7 (Translation) The righteous man who lives a life of integrity– How blessed are his children after him!
{}	
	20:8 (Translation) The king sits on the judgment seat, Scatters with his eyes every evil.
“[P]roverbs like this assume a just government that cares for people who are poor and in need. God intended for Israel to have that kind of government (see Deuteronomy 24:17-22). A corrupt government often thwarts the plans of godly men and women and exploits people who are poor” (Barton et al. 1031).	
20:9 (Paraphrase) There is simply no one who is without sin!	20:9 (Translation) Who can say, “I am pure in my heart; “I am clean from my sin”?
“Be diligent, apply it all, But brace yourself, for you will fall. You'll stumble when both pushed and tried– But Jesus for your sins has died. So mourn your sins, and cling to grace, And get right up–rejoin the race. Raise your head forlornly hung, For God will heal both ear and tongue” (Shorey, 226).	
	20:10 (Translation)

	A stone and a[nother] stone, and a weight and a[nother] weight— An abomination to Yahweh are both of them.
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{ }

	20:11 (Translation) Even a young man is recognizable by his deeds, Whether his work is pure and upright.
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{ }

	20:12 (Translation) The hearing ear and the seeing eye— Yahweh made both of them.
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{ }

	20:13 (Translation) Do not love sleep, let you be disinherited. Open your eyes! Be satisfied with food!
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{ }

	20:14 (Translation) “Bad, bad,” says the buyer, But when he goes on his way, he boasts.
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{Don't take peoples' words overmuch to heart in the bargaining process?? check Waltke} “This proverb is actually a vignette. It pictures a scene in the bazaar in which a ‘*buyer*’ chisels down the price of an article—say a pot or a blanket—by bad-mouthing it: ‘Bad, bad’ is what he ‘*cries*.’ You can see the scowl on his face and the gesticulating of his hands as he inspects and criticizes the proposed purchase. In despair the seller lowers the price to an indecent level, and the buyer reluctantly shells it out still protesting the highway robbery. Once out of sight, his tone changes. He floods himself with self-centered ‘*boasts*’... No sense of fairness present here, no law of neighbor love at work!” (Hubbard, 311).

	20:15 (Translation) There is gold, and there are many pearls, But the most precious item is knowledgeable lips.
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{ }

	20:16 (Translation) { }
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{ }

	20:17 (Translation) The bread of falsehood is sweet to a man, But later his mouth is full of gravel.
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{ }

	20:18 (Translation) Plans by counsel will be established, So [only] with consultation embark on a war.
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{}

	20:19 (Translation) {}
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{}

	20:20 (Translation) {}
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Scripture prescribes a position of authority and honor for parents as it relates to their own children, and violation of this principle is a serious offense indeed, despite how common violations are in American culture. “The modern habit is to evaluate the person rather than the office (e.g. to be respectful to one's master or faithful to one's partner if they *evoke* such a response, not because it is *owed* to them in their position). The Old Testament law instilled the opposite attitude from childhood, and the New Testament supports it (e.g. Eph. 6:1-9, 1 Pet. 2:13-18)” (Kidner 131). Of course, respect for the office is not *ultimate* (Ac 5:29), but for the Christian it should be the *norm*.

	20:21 (Translation) An inheritance hastily gained at the beginning Will not in its latter days be blessed.
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	20:22 (Translation) Do not say, “I must recompense this evil”; [Instead,] hope in Yahweh, and he will save you.
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{}

	20:23 (Translation) The use of two different weights is an abomination to Yahweh, And deceptive scales are not good.
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	20:24 (Translation) From Yahweh are the steps on a man, But as for a [mere] human, how shall he discern his [own] way?
--	---

“The emphases fall on *the Lord* and *man*. The saying is relevant both to the Lord's prescribed part for us to play (Ps. 37:23; our improvising cannot compare to his composing) and to his overruling of us (we cannot see what order he will bring from our confusion: cf. Gen. 50:20; 1 Kgs 12:15)” (Kidner 123).

	20:25 (Translation) It is a snare for a man rashly to declare, “Sanctified!”
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	And [only] afterward to contemplate [the cost of keeping his] vows.
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20:26 (Paraphrase) A wise king sets about defeating the wicked, using the most powerful instruments at his disposal to do so.	20:26 (Translation) A wise king scatters the wicked, And directs against them the [chariot] wheel.
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It is sometimes said that the chariot was the ancient world's equivalent of the tank. Whether that analogy is precise or not, the point is well taken that the chariot was a symbol of military might. When Solomon says “the wicked” here, he does not mean shop-lifters, but the violent and exploitative (such as those pictured in 1:10-18); there is a place for armed law enforcement and military defense.

	20:27 (Translation) The lamp of Yahweh is the breath of humankind, Searching out all the chambers of the inner person.
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{}

	20:28 (Translation) Grace and truth will keep the king, And by loyal love his throne will be sustained.
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{}

	20:29 (Translation) The glory of young men is their strength, And the splendor of old men is gray hair.
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Contrary to what American culture teaches, the second line is *not* ironic: Physical signs of advancing age, such as gray hair, are *not* signs of having passed our relevance or usefulness, but just the opposite. The young have something to offer with their muscles; the elderly have something to offer with their *mind*.

	20:30 (Translation) {}
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	21:1 (Translation) The mind of a king is like channels of water in the hands of Yahweh: He diverts it whichever direction he chooses.
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“Tiglath-pileser (Isa. 10:6,7), Cyrus (Isa. 41:2-4) and Artaxerxes (Ezra 7:21) are all examples of autocrats who, in pursuing their chosen courses, flooded or fertilized God's field as he chose” (Kidner 133).

	21:2 (Translation) {}
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{}

	21:3 (Translation)
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	The doing of righteousness and justice— These are in Yahweh's eyes preferable to sacrifice.
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{ }

	21:4 (Translation) Height of eyes and breath of mind— The domain of the wicked is sin.
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{ } “Pride is pagan behavior. It should have no place in the lives of God’s people. Israel’s teachers, psalmists, chroniclers, and prophets were unanimous on that point[, as are the writings of the New Testament]. Pride was, for them, a rejection of creatureliness, a declaration of independence from God if not an announcement of war against Him” (Hubbard, 332).

	21:5 (Translation) Diligent plans led only to profit, And everything that is hasty leads only to lack.
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“Most if not all get-rich-quick schemes are some kind of deception and are nothing but scams. Unfortunately, even God's people have been duped by scam artists, and more than one trusting soul has lost his or her life savings in a 'sure thing' that turned out to be a sure loser. However, scams wouldn't succeed if there weren't people eager to get rich as quickly and as easily as possible. But as the old adage puts it, 'There are no free lunches’” (Wiersbe 102).

21:6 (Paraphrase) Money through lies leaves you with nothing, except a free pass to the grave.	21:6 (Translation) The acquisition of treasuries with a deceitful tongue Is a vapor blown about, [and] death's snare.
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Trying to amass riches through cunning ploys will leave a person running here and there with nothing ultimately to show for it—and what's more, that person is really the one being deceived, for Death grins from ear to ear when he sees someone playing this game. Slow and steady integrity is a better, and safer, alternative.

{ }	21:7 (Translation) The ruin of the wicked terrifies them, For they have refused to enact justice.
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21:8 (Paraphrase) Wicked people would rather plan out evil deeds than hang out and have a nice time with other people.	21:8 (Translation) The soul of the wicked man desires evil; His neighbor does not find favor in his eyes.
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There is a play on words in the Hebrew: The word for “evil” and the word for “neighbor” sound similar. Allowing sin to seep into the soul is like putting on broken glasses—instead of seeing chances for friendship, instead of seeing the common grace of life, a person sees only hurt and how to worsen hurt.

	21:9 (Translation) It is better to dwell on the corner of the roof Than with a { }
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	21:10 (Translation) The wicked man desires evil;
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	He will not receive grace in the eyes of his neighbor.
	21:11 (Translation) When the scoffer is punished, the naive becomes wise; And when the wise man is instructed, he receives knowledge.
	21:12 (Translation) {}
{Re translation, see Tawil}	
	21:13 (Translation) He who closes his ear to the cry of the poor– He too will [one day] call out with no one answering.
“We can sin against the poor by neglect as well as by oppression... If we shut our ears and close our eyes, pretending to be ignorant of their plight, God will take note of it and shut His eyes to our needs and His ears to our prayers—and so will other people. We will reap what we sow” (Wiersbe 196).	
	21:14 (Translation) A gift [given] in secret averts anger, And a bribe behind closed doors [averts] severe wrath.
{Waltke?} I tentatively take this as a descriptive, not a prescriptive, proverb. That is, it does not describe what should happen but what often does—the punishment that rightly should come to the lawbreaking business mogul is averted by a secret deal. An alternative interpretation of this verse is worth mentioning, however. This “should not be read as a justification for bribery, which is condemned elsewhere in Prov. 15:27; 17:23. The context of 21:14 is not a court of law or a delicate financial transaction. It is a case of ruptured relationships, personal misunderstandings that have left someone blazing with ‘<i>anger</i>’ and ‘<i>strong wrath</i>.’ The cautious person ‘<i>pacifies</i>,’ turns aside, averts... those intense feelings by offering a ‘<i>gift</i>’ or a ‘present’ (‘<i>bribe</i>’ is a misleading translation here; 1 Kings 15:19; 2 Kings 16:8; Prov 17:8) as an expression of friendship and an overture of peace. ‘<i>In secret</i>’ and ‘<i>behind the back</i>’... do not intimate crookedness but privacy; the giver’s desire is not to embarrass the angry companion but to give space for the anger to abate unnoticed by outsiders. An act of kindness or generosity quietly rendered can be one of the answer that turns away wrath (15:1)” (Huubard, 344-345).	
21:15 (Paraphrase) {}	21:15 (Translation) The doing of justice is a joy to the righteous, But horrible in the eyes of workers of iniquity.
It has been noted that if the digit “6” was lying on the ground, two people, if standing on opposite ends of it, would look at the same object but interpret it on the one hand as a “6” and on the other hand as a “9.” The point to be taken from this visualization is not that it’s all a matter of perspective (though many things are), but that sometimes a thing can evoke opposite reactions in people. In many instances (not all—this is a proverb, after all), God’s way of doing things brings feelings of delight to Christians but feelings of revulsion to non-christians.	
	21:16 (Translation) A man wanders from the path of prudence Will come to rest in the ghostly assembly.

21:17 (Paraphrase) He who is obsessed with the finest things in life might end up with nothing in this life.	21:17 (Translation) A man of lack is he who loves happiness; He who loves wine and oil will not become rich.
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Excessive interest in fine food and drink, in fancy clothes and jewelry, will tend to sap one's monetary resources. Christians do not need to shop in the best stores or always have new clothes.

	21:18 (Translation) The wicked man is a ransom for the righteous, And the treacherous man is in place of the upright.
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"Isaiah 43:3, 4 uses such language for the fall of nations which cleared the path of Cyrus to Babylon and the liberation of Israel; Luke 13:1-5 warns us, however, against reading all events in such terms. Against this background we can appreciate the reversal of roles in Mark 10:45; 1 Peter 3:18, etc." (Kidner 136).

{ }	21:19 (Translation) Better to dwell in a desert land Than with a contentious and bitter woman.
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	21:20 (Translation) Exquisite treasure dwells in the abode of the wise, But a foolish man swallows it up.
--	--

	21:21 (Translation) He who pursues righteousness and love Will find life, righteousness, and honor.
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Cf. Rom 2:6-11. Read in isolation, this proverb might be thought to teach salvation by works, but the balanced Christian will read it against the backdrop of the whole of the Bible's teaching. (For that matter, certain passages about salvation by grace might, if read in isolation, be thought to say that { })

	21:22 (Translation) A wise man goes up to a city of warriors, And its confident strength falls.
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(Wordplay up // down; cities generally on a hill; wisdom > strength) { }

21:23 (Paraphrase) "Wise is the person who knows what to say but when not to say it." ²³	21:23 (Translation) He who guards his mouth and his tongue Protects his life from troubles.
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{ }

	21:24 (Translation) The presumptuous one—"mockers" is his name, Acting in the outburst of presumption.
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{ }

²³ I read this somewhere, I think in a copy of the *Our Daily Bread* devotional.

	21:25 (Translation) The desire[s] of the lazy man will put him to death, For he refuses to work with his hands.
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“The negative obstacles to an adequate food supply were not a malevolent creation which was out to destroy humankind. No true Israelite, nurtured on Genesis, Psalms, Job, and Isaiah, could have believed that. Demons were not the enemies, nor hostile spirits... Even the stony soil and low annual rainfall... were not the subject of attention. Human resolve was. One could choose to work hard or not” (Hubbard, 155). True, sometimes poverty is an effect of causes completely outside of a person’s control. This proverb, however, turns its tense on “lazy man” who “refused to work.” A person’s will, not his or her environment, is ultimately the key.

21:26 (Paraphrase) If you are fixated on your desires, you will be continually unsatisfied. If you are righteous, you will be generous towards others.	21:26 (Translation) Desire longs [for the object of its desire] all day, Yet the righteous gives and does not hold back.
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“The sluggard lives in his world of wishing, which is his substitute for working. It can ruin him materially ([v]25) and imprison him spiritually (26), for he can neither command himself nor escape himself. Contrast with this the outflowing interest and energy of the *righteous* man (26b)” (Kidner 137).

21:28 (Paraphrase) God hates what wicked men bring to his altar, and all the more when this is part of some conspiracy.	21:27 (Translation) The sacrifice of a wicked man is an abomination— How much more when it is brought with scheming!
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Cf. 1 Sam 15:22, Isa 1:11-15, Hos 6:6. On the interweaving of a conspiracy, take as an example the fate of Naboth, in whose case the name of God was invoked in order to bring about a wicked seizure of property (1 Ki 21:13). One must not think that one can purchase God's favor.

21:28 (Paraphrase) Schemes will soon be silenced, but respect wins respect.	21:28 (Translation) As lying witness will disappear, But a man who hears [well] will speak forever.
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“The key phrase is *a man who hears*: his first aim is to know and understand, not to grind some axe. It is not without relevance to Christian 'witness': the man who listens (Isa. 50:4) is the man worth listening to” (Kidner 137).

21:29 (Paraphrase) The wicked might be determined, but it is the righteous whose desires will be actualized.	21:29 (Translation) A wicked man hardens his face, But the upright man is the one who establishes his way.
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“[A] bold front is no substitute for sound principles” (Kidner 137).

	21:30 (Translation) There is no wisdom, nor discernment, Nor counsel before {against? So BDB; check commentaries} Yahweh.
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{}

	21:31 (Translation)
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	The horse is prepared for the day of battle, But victory belongs to Yahweh.
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{}

22:1 (Paraphrase) Good reputation > great wealth	22:1 (Translation) A [reputable] name is more desirable than great wealth, And good favor [is more desirable] than silver or gold.
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As I write this commentary, various rich and famous men have recently fallen into public dishonor as their patterns of sin have become evident. I imagine similar things have been happening throughout history. Whenever there is a choice between maintaining integrity and increasing wealth, the former must prevail.

	22:2 (Translation) The rich and the poor encounter one another; The maker of all of them is Yahweh.
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	22:3 (Translation) { } {see 27:12}
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	22:4 (Translation) The reward for humility (the fear of Yahweh) Is wealth and honor and life.
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	22:5 (Translation) Thorny traps are on the path of the perverse; He who guards his soul keeps far from them.
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	22:6 (Translation) Train a youth according to his way; Even when he is old, he will not depart from it.
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In the literal translation above I have attempted to capture at least some of the ambiguities of the Hebrew: Does “his” refer to God, in which case the meaning is “Train a youth to follow God’s directives”; or does it refer to the young man, in which case the meaning is “Train a youth in a way that matches his personality”? The second interpretation seems a bit more likely, since God is not mentioned in the immediate context, such that “his” most naturally refers to the young man just mentioned. (Recall that Proverbs is written from the male perspective; it is not hard in this case to swap out the male pronouns for female pronouns.) Just possibly the proverb is meant to be ambiguous in order to prompt hearers to contemplate both aspects of child rearing: Children must be trained to obey God, but they must also be trained differently, inasmuch as each child has a different interests, habits, and ways of the looking at the world. The second line of the proverb, it must be stressed, is a proverb, not a promise (so also, e.g., Hubbard, 304). Sad to say, sometimes people reared in Christian homes do walk away from God’s ways later in life, and this does not mean that their parents did not do their job properly. Also, to some extent personalities and perspectives do often change in the course of life.

	22:7 (Translation) A rich man rules over the poor,
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	And the borrower is servant to the lender.
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	22:8 (Translation) He who sows sin will reap sorrow, And the rod of his wrath will consume him.
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	22:9 (Translation) The good eye—it is blessed, For it gives from its [store of] food to the poor.
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	22:10 (Translation) Send away the scoffer, and contention will leave, And adjudication and ignominy will cease.
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“Disagreement and bad blood sometimes arise not from the facts of a situation but from a *person* with a wrong attitude, who makes mischief. That is to say, what an institution sometimes needs is not reforms, but the expulsion of a member; see Matthew 18:17” (Kidner 139).

	22:11 (Translation) He who loves purity of heart, Whose lips are grace[-filled], the king is his friend.
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22:12 (Paraphrase) {	22:12 (Translation) The eyes of Yahweh have [always] guarded knowledge, And have [always] subverted the words of the treacherous.
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}

22:13 (Paraphrase) The lazy man thought to himself, “A comet might hit my car, so I better not go to work today.”	22:13 (Translation) The lazy man thinks, “There is a lion outside! “In the midst of the streets I shall be murdered!”
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Laziness generates nothing but an endless supply of irrational excuses.

22:14 (Paraphrase) Sin is a black hole: Get too close, and you might never escape.	22:14 (Translation) A deep pit is the mouth of wickedness; The one with whom Yahweh is angry falls into it.
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God retains the prerogative to punish evil by allowing the one who sins against him to fall into a cycle of deeper and deeper sin (cf. Gen 15:16, Rom 1:24).

22:15 (Paraphrase) Young people and bad decisions go together until discipline comes along to separate them.	22:15 (Translation) Foolishness clings to the heart of a young man; The rod of discipline puts it far from him.
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“We are not born knowing how to make sound choices. Our instincts run toward self-centeredness” (Hubbard, 304).

	22:16 (Translation) He who oppresses the poor for the sole purpose of enriching himself Gives to the rich with the sole effect of impoverishing himself.
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{eschatological perspective?}

	22:17-23:11 (Translation) Incline your ear and hear words of the wise, And let your mind pay attention to my knowledge. 18 For it is pleasant that you should guard them in your inner person; Let them be ready together on your tongue, 19 So that your confidence will be in Yahweh; I will instruct you, even you, today. 20 Have I not translated for you “The Thirty” In counsel and in knowledge, 21 To teach you verity, speaking truth, So that you can return words of truth to those who sent you? 22 Do not rob a poor man because he is poor, And do not crush the oppressed in the gate. 23 For Yahweh will take of their case, And rob their robbers of their soul. 24 Do not befriend an angry man, And do not go along with wrathful man, 25 Otherwise you will learn his ways, And find a snare for your soul. 26 Do not be among those who clasp the hand {} 27 For if you do have anything with you to repay, Why should your bed beneath you be taken? 28 Do not move the ancient boundary Which your fathers set. 29 Have you seen a man skilled in his occupation? Before kings he will stand; He will not stand before men of little account. 23:1 When you sit down to eat with a ruler, Carefully discern what is before you, 2 And put a knife to your throat If you are man of notable appetite. 3 Do not desire his delicacies, For it is deceitful food. 4 Do not toil to become rich; [Instead,] from your discernment gain good success. 5 Has your eye alighted upon it, and [then suddenly] it is gone, For gives itself wings like a vulture flying heavenward?
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	6 [If that has been your experience, Do not eat the bread of jealousy, And do not desire its delicacies, 7 For like one who calculates within himself, so is he [who has invited you to the meal]: “Eat and drink,” he says to you, But his heart is not with you. 8 The morsel you have eaten you will vomit up, And you will spoil your pleasant words. 9 Do not speak in the hearing of a fool, For he will scorn the prudence of your words. 10 Do not move the ancient boundary, And do not go to the orphans' fields. 11 For their redeemer is strong, And he will take up their case against you.
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Additional Note

{background of this passage; ?v20 “translated”}

23:12 (Paraphrase) Make sure you are taking in profitable content that helps you live a meaningful and informed life.	23:12 (Translation) Make your heart engage with discipline, And your ears with knowledgeable words.
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One must be intentional if one is to fill one's mind with heavenly thoughts (Phil 4:8, Col 3:2). In this world it is easy to fill one's eyes and ears with what is either wrong or valueless. Scrolling on social media platforms or watching entertaining movies is—depending on the content—not necessarily wrong, but one must limit the time one spends on these things, or the present proverb will have been ignored. As John Piper entitled a book of his (which I have not read, but I think the title speaks for itself), “*Don't Waste Your Life.*”

23:13-14 (Paraphrase) As much as you hate to see your disciplined child cry, discipline will not destroy him—on the contrary, if you do your duty [as a parent], you might well save his life from death [later on].	23:13-14 (Translation) Do not withhold discipline from a young man; Though he weeps, he will not die. 14 You yourself strike him with a rod, For his soul you will [thus] deliver from Sheol.
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“Discipline has to do with correcting character faults in a child while there is still time to do it... Better the child is corrected by a parent than by a law enforcement officer in a correctional institution” (Wiersbe 124). Of course, the discipline must not be overly harsh (Col 3:21); and the form it takes does not necessarily need to be corporal punishment, as the author of this proverb envisions, since it is a proverb rather than a detailed prescription.

	23:15-16 (Translation) My son, if your heart is wise, My hearty will rejoice as well, 16 And my inner being will rejoice When your lips speak rightly.
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When a person is doing well spiritually, that brings joy not only to that person, but to his or her mentors (cf. Lk 15:32).

23:17-18 (Paraphrase) Don't spend your mental energy on wanting what sinners have. Focus on what God wants you to do, and then you will have treasures in heaven.	23:17-18 (Translation) Do not let your heart be jealous of sinners, But rather [let your heart be zealous] for the fear of Yahweh, 18 For if you keep it there is a future [for you], And your hope will not be cut off.
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v17 turns on the fact that the Hebrew verb (אָנַף) has a double meaning: "To be jealous" or "to be zealous." {}

	23:19-21 (Translation) Listen, my son, and be wise, And I will direct your heart on the way [in which it should go]. 20 Do not hang around those who constantly drink wine, [And do not hang around] those who [constantly] treat themselves to the finest meats, 21 For those addicted to wine and to fine meat will become impoverished, And laziness clothes [one] with rags.
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{}

	23:22-25 (Translation) Listen to your father who begot you, And do not scorn when your mother becomes old. 23 Buy truth, and do not sell [it], [And hold on to] wisdom and discipline and discernment. 24 The father of a righteous man will rejoice greatly; [Indeed,] he who begets a wise man [will rejoice greatly], and he will be glad in him. 25 May your father and mother be glad, And may the one who bore you rejoice.
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{v22 Watch out for ageism}

	23:26-28 (Translation) Give, my son, [the attention of] your mind to me, And let your eyes keep a close watch on my ways. 27 For a wicked woman is [like] a deep pit, And an unfaithful woman is [like] a narrow cistern. 28 Indeed, she lies in wait as for prey, And [the number of] the treacherous among men she increases.
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	23:29-35 (Translation) Whose is woe? Whose is contention? Whose is complaint? Whose is bruising without provocation?
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	Whose is darkness of eyes? 30 They belong to those who linger over wine, To those who come to investigate mixed wine. 31 Do not look on wine when it sparkles, When it winks in the cup, Going down smoothly. 32 Its aftermath is like the bite of an adder Or like a cobra spreading its hood. 33 Your eyes will see strange things, And your mind will speak absurdities. 34 And you will be like someone sleeping in the middle of the sea, Or like someone sleeping on the top of a mast. 35 [You will yourself saying things like,] “They struck me, but I am not injured. “I do not know when I will wake up. “I will look for another one.”
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“Saving Mr. Banks”?

	24:1-2 (Translation) Do not be jealous of an evil man, And do not desire to be with them. 2 For their minds murmur destruction, And their lips speak evil.
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	24:3-4 (Translation) A house will be established by wisdom, And by discernment it will be established. 4 And with knowledge the rooms will be filled With everything valuable, precious, and pleasant.
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	24:5-6 (Translation) A wise man is stronger than a warrior, And a knowledgeable man [is stronger] than a mighty man, 6 For with consultations you {must? will?} wage war, and with a multitude of counselors [you will secure] victory.
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}

	24:7 (Translation) Wisdom is too high for a fool; He will not open his mouth in the gate.
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}

	24:8 (Translation)
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	One who devises harm Will be called a schemer.
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	24:9 (Translation) The scheme of foolishness is sin, And a scoffer is an abomination to humankind.
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{}

	24:10 (Translation) If you show yourself lazy in the day of trouble, Your strength will leave you.
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{}

	24:11-12 (Translation) Deliver those being taken away to death; Or will you hold back from those headed for the sword? 13 But if you say, “Behold, we did not know this,” Does not he know weights hearts himself perceive, And he who guards your soul himself know, And render to each human being according to his work?
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{}

	24:13-14 (Translation) My son, eat honey, because it is good, And let sweet honeycomb be on your palate. 14 Thus recognize wisdom for your soul: If you find it, then there is a future for you, And your hope will not be cut off.
--	--

v13 must be read in context: It prepares the way for v14. Just as honey is sweet and pleasurable, the life of wisdom brings great joy, specifically eternal life in the presence of God (cf. Mat 13:44).

	24:15-16 (Translation) Wicked man, do not lie in wait to attack the righteous man’s dwelling, Nor attack his resting place. 16 For though the righteous man might fall seven times, he will rise, But wicked men will stumble in the coming of disaster.
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{}

	24:17-18 (Translation) When your enemy falls, do not be happy,
--	--

	And when he stumbles, do not let your heart rejoice. 18 Otherwise Yahweh will see, and it will displease him, And he will turn his anger from him.
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Wilson points to similar verses elsewhere (20:22, 25:21-22, Job 31:29, Mat. 5:34-44) that warn against “even an inner delight (*your heart*) when your enemy stumbles (*Schadenfreunde*)” (261). God takes no pleasure in the death of the wicked (Eze 33:11), so much so that God might punish a vindictive spirit by forbearing from punishing the wicked. If this seems unfair, we should remember God's absolute sovereignty (Rom 9:20), and the fact that if any of us stands, it is because of God's grace (Ps 130:3).

	24:19-20 (Translation) Do not be agitated concerning evildoers; Do not be furious at wicked men. 20 For there will be no future for the evil person; The lamp of the wicked will be extinguished.
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24:21-22 (Paraphrase) My child, hold the Lord in respect, and hold the king of the land in respect as well; don't involve yourself in the plots of revolutionaries, for catastrophe comes to them quickly, and the wrath of God and of the monarch alike will stagger the imagination.	24:21-22 (Translation) Fear Yahweh, my son, and the king [also]; With do become mixed up with rebels. 22 For their disaster will come suddenly; And the ruin of both, who can comprehend?
---	--

There is some uncertainty about the translation of v21b, but not in a way that affects the basic meaning of the verse. Cf. Rom 13:1. As for v22, one thinks of the French Revolution: Violent men overthrew and slew the French monarch, but, after a brief reign of terror, many of them were eventually killed by the forces of terror they themselves had unleashed (making way, ironically enough, for another autocrat, Napoleon, to take power).

24:23b {} {} See further the comments on 25:1.	24:23a (Translation) These are also sayings of the wise.
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	24:24b-25 (Translation) He who says to the wicked, “You are innocent”— Peoples and nations will curse him. 25 But those who reprove will be approval, And on them will come a good blessing. {} {} See further the comments on 25:1.
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24:26 (Paraphrase) Replying honestly and with good intent is like giving a warm hug or a firm handshake. {} {} See further the comments on 25:1.	24:26 (Translation) [Like] one that kisses the lips is He who returns words that are good and right.
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	24:27 (Translation) Establish your work outside, And prepare it in a field for yourself;
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	Afterwards build your house.
--	------------------------------

{About necessary prep work?}

	24:28 (Translation) Do not be without cause a witness against your neighbor, Or lie with your lips.
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See 6:19 and the comments there. One way that this proverb complements that one is that this one is placed alongside a call to avoid vindictiveness (24:29); this might suggest that where there is friction between two people, the temptation to lie maliciously is greater than it normally would be.

24:29 (Paraphrase) Never pay back evil with more evil (Rom 12:17, NLT).	24:29 (Translation) Do not say, “As he did, So I will do to him; I will return to the man according to his deed.”
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	24:30-34 (Translation) Over the lazy man's field I crossed, And over the vineyard of a human lacking sense. 31 And I saw a striking sight: Thistles had gone up all over it, Weeds covered its surface, And its stone[wall]s had been torn down. 32 And I saw, [and] took it to heart; I saw, [and] I grasped discipline: 33 [You, the lazy man, have this to say:] “A little sleep, a little slumber, “A little folding of the hands to lie down,” 34 So your poverty will come [like] a robber, [And] your lack [will come] like an armed man.
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25:1 (Paraphrase) Starting here, there will be more proverbs from Solomon. These proverbs were not originally part of this collection, but Hezekiah commissioned scholarly work collecting some more of Solomon’s proverbs to create an expanded edition of the book.	25:1 (Translation) These also are proverbs of Solomon, which men of Hezekiah, king of Judah, transcribed.
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Here we get a rare glimpse of the process lying behind a book of the Bible. {Cf. Ac 1:1ff}

	25:2-7 (Translation) It is the glory of God to conceal a matter, And it is the glory of kings to reveal it. 3 The height of the heavens, and the depth of the earth, And the mind of the king—none can be [adequately]
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	measured. 4 Dross is driven from silver, And something useful emerges for the refiner. 5 [Similarly,] the wicked is driven out from the presence of the king That he may establish his throne with righteousness. 6 Do not seek honor before the king, Nor in the place of great men take a stand. 7 For it is better for him to say to you, “Come here” Than for you to be put in your place in front of the nobles whom your eyes have seen.
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{idealized picture, most fully seen in Christ, who (Jn 1) reveals the Father}

re v2: “Order there will always be in God’s ways but always order with mystery” (Hubbard, 389).

	25:8-10 (Translation) Do not rush into litigation, So that you will not afterward find yourself speechless When your neighbor puts you to shame. 9 Work out your dispute with your neighbor [alone], And do not reveal someone else’s secret, 10 Lest the person who hears it puts you to shame, For the report about you cannot be retracted.
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{}

	25:11-13 (Translation) Apples of gold in a statue of silver Is a word spoken in the right way. 12 A ring of gold and jewelry of fine gold Is someone who reproves a wise man concerning perceptive listening. 13 Like the coolness of snow on harvest day Is a faithful messenger to the one who sent him, And the soul of his lord is revived.
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{}

25:14 (Paraphrase) {}	25:14 (Translation) Like mist and wind where there is no rain Is the man who boasts deceptive gifts.
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{}

25:15 (Paraphrase) {}	25:15 (Translation) Being slow to anger can beguile a ruler, And a soft tongue breaks bones.
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{Few things are more powerful than self-control}

25:16 (Translation) Enjoy that pie, but not so much that you puke.	25:16 (Translation) Have you found honey? Eat what is sufficient for you, So that you do not become full of it and vomit it up.
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When it comes to sweet things (I think it is safe to apply what is said here about honey to sugar, though some might differ on this point), this proverb says that you should go ahead and enjoy them when the opportunity presents itself (cf. 16:24, 24:13),²⁴ but not to excess. Too much honey (or sugar) will make you sick. Vomiting provides a vivid (and in some cases, literal) image of the consequences for those who fail to heed this warning.

25:17 (Paraphrase) Don't always be banging on your friend's door, or that door might become a wall.	25:17 (Translation) Make your foot scarce in the house of your friend, So that he does not have enough of you and hate you.
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Recently in American Christianity there has been some discussion of “boundaries,” “bandwidth,” and related terms. I suspect that much of this is overemphasized or misplaced, but there is some truth to the non-biblical proverb that says, “Too much of a good thing is a bad thing.” Your friend no doubt appreciates your company—(s)he is your friend, after all—yet your constant, unrelenting presence will tend to sour the relationship: He or she might feel used by you, unable to catch their breath, or otherwise smothered. Being “scarce” might be an overstatement for effect (just like “hate” in the second line), but at any rate you should not overstay your welcome.

25:18 (Paraphrase) Perjury is perilous to life and limb.	25:18 (Translation) A club, sword, or sharp arrow Is one who answers his neighbor by a false witness.
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This proverb speaks concerning deliberately spoken falsehood in a legal setting, though its application is surely broader than that. The proverb is—perhaps purposefully—ambiguous as to just who stands to be injured in such cases (the one lying or the one lied about). But the point is clear (and sharp): Deception of this kind is no small matter, but a deadly affair; and you must remember that “those who take the sword will die by the sword” (Mat 26:52).

	25:19 (Translation) A bad tooth or a wobbly leg Is a treacherous source of confidence in a day of trouble.
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{ }

	25:20 (Translation) Vinegar on natron Is the singing of songs to a despairing heart.
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Scripture elsewhere takes a lot of space singing songs of lament and comfort. The meaning here is apparently that singing frivolous, silly, or excessively upbeat songs to someone who is depressed is only going to make their pain worse. Sometimes {a quiet presence} is better.

	25:21-22 (Translation)
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²⁴ The Hebrew behind “Have you found honey?” does, however, seem to suggest a bit of surprise (notice the interrogative wording, and the fronting of the object for emphasis) that honey has been found; I suspect that this surprise stems from the fact that in ancient Israel sweet things were relatively rare. In many parts of the world today the situation is quite the opposite, cheap, sugar-intensive products flooding local markets.

	If your enemy is hungry, feed him something to eat, And if he is thirsty, give him something to drink, 22 For your scoop burning coals onto his head, For Yahweh will recompense you.
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{ }

	25:23 (Translation) {same as 21:9}
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{ }

	25:24 (Translation) Better is { }
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{ }

	25:25 (Translation) Cold water for a weary soul Is good news from a distant land.
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{ }

	25:26 (Translation) A muddied well and a soiled cistern Is a righteous man moving before the wicked.
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{ }

25:27 (Paraphrase) Consuming sugar is best kept infrequent, and likewise offering opinions.	25:27 (Translation) Eating large amount of honey is not good, And making words scarce is an honor.
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Some things are better in moderation—sweet food and speaking one's mind above all.

25:28 (Paraphrase) { }	25:28 (Translation) A city broken into with no wall Is a man who has no self-control for his spirit.
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A lack of self-control leaves a person defenseless, like a city with no walls in the face of a hostile army. Protection is to be found in restraint; safety is the possession of the even-keeled. And a person who can control his tongue is the most self-controlled of all (Jm 3:2).

	26:1 (Translation) Like snow in summer or rain in the harvest, Likewise honor is not fitting for a fool.
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{ }

	26:2 (Translation) Like a sparrow who wanders or a dove who flies around A baseless curse will not land.
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}

	26:3 (Translation) A crop is for a horse, a bridle for a mule; And a rod for the back of fools.
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}

	26:4-5 (Translation) Do not answer a fool according to his folly So that you, too, will not seem to be foolish like him. 5 Answer a fool according to his folly So that he will not be wise in his own eyes.
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}

	26:6 (Translation) He cuts off in own feet, drinking in violence, Who sends a message in the hands of a fool.
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}

	26:7-9 (Translation) The legs of a lame man hang [useless], And also a proverb in the mouth of a fool. 8 Like putting sling stones in a chest for gems, So is giving honor to a fool. 9 A thorn in the hand of a drunk man, And a proverb in the mouth of fools.
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}

26:10 (Paraphrase) Drunkenness causes bodily discoordination terrible to witness, like a ship being heaved by storm waves.	26:10 (Translation) The whole body of a fool writhes terribly, And the drunkard [feels as though he] crosses the sea.
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26:11 (Paraphrase) “The definition of insanity is doing the same thing over and over and expecting a different result.” ²⁵	26:11 (Translation) Like a dog returns to its vomit, A fool repeats his foolishness.
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{2 Pet 2}

	26:12 (Translation) Have you seen a man wise in his own eyes? There is more hope for a fool than for him.
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{ “That you are wrong you may assume—And by this give the truth some room” (Shorey, 226).

²⁵ This quotation is often attributed to Albert Einstein, but the saying seems rather to have originated within Alcoholics Anonymous (<https://quoteinvestigator.com/2017/03/23/same>).

	26:13-16 (Translation) The lazy man says, “There is a lion on the road, “A lion in the middle of the street!” 14 The door turns on its pivot, And the lazy man turns on his bed. 15 The lazy man buries his hand in the dish; He is too weary to bring it back to his mouth. 16 The lazy man is wiser in his own eyes Than seven people bringing back a decision.
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{}

	26:17-21 (Translation) A man seizing a dog by its ears Is a passerby getting mixed up in a dispute that is not his. 18 Like a man man hurling Fiery arrows and death, 19 So is a man who deceives his neighbor And says, “I was just joking!” 20 Without wood, the fire is extinguished And without whispering, strife goes silent. 21 Charcoal for hot coals and wood for fire— And a man of strife to kindle contention.
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{the verb in v19a is a malicious one, not good-natured humor}

	26:22-28 (Translation) The words of one whispering dissension are like delicacies, For they go down [delightfully] into the chambers of the belly. 23 {} {} 24 {} {} 25 {} {} 26 {} {} 27 {} {} 28 {} {}
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{}

27:1 (Paraphrase) Don't count your chickens before they hatch.	27:1 (Translation) Do not boast in tomorrow's day, For you do not know what tomorrow will give birth to.
--	---

It is unwise to *assume* that an investment will pay out to the extent hoped for, or that revenue will surpass

expenses, or otherwise to act in the present as though some future positive outcome was assured. Neither the stock market, nor crop yields, nor any other fact of daily life is sufficiently predictable. (James expands on this theme in 4:13-17 of his epistle.)

	27:2 (Translation) Let a stranger praise you, and not your mouth; [Let] a foreigner [praise you], and not your lips.
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	27:3 (Translation) The heaviness of a stone or the weight of the sand— Yet the provocation from a foolish man is a greater burden than both of them.
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{}

	27:4 (Translation) Cruelty, rage, and outbursts of anger— Yet who can withstand jealousy?
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{}

27:5 (Paraphrase) {}	27:5 (Translation) Better open reproof Than hidden love.
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If someone tells us something we've done wrong, we might be annoyed, but at least we've learned of an area that needs improvement. But if someone loves us but never tells us or shows us, it does no good at all. {}

	27:6 (Translation) Faithful are the wounds of a friend, And the kisses of an enemy are self-serving.
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{}

27:8 (Paraphrase) A satisfied stomach detests delicacies; hunger is the best seasoning.	27:7 (Translation) A satisfied appetite treads on dripping honey, But for the hungry any bitter thing is sweet.
--	--

{}

	27:8 (Translation) Like a bird wondering from her nest Is a man wandering from his place.
--	--

{Scholars straying outside their subject matter, like pastors giving medical advice}

	27:9 (Translation) Oil and incense might make the mind glad, Yet one can [still] be rent by grief in the soul.
--	---

A similar thought occurs in 14:13 (Fox 352).

	27:10 (Translation) Do not abandon your friend or your father's friend, And do not go to your brother's house in the day of your calamity; Better is a neighbor who is nearby than a relative who is far off.
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{}

27:11 (Paraphrase) Keep your standards high, and your father will hold his head high.	27:11 (Translation) Be wise, my son, and make my heart glad, So that I can make a response to those who reproach me.
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{}

	27:12 (Translation) The perceptive see evil and hide{}
--	--

{Cf. 22:3}

	27:13 (Translation) {} And {} foreigners {}
--	--

	27:14 (Translation) He who blesses his neighbor with a loud voice in the morning Will early have a curse reckoned to him.{?}
--	--

{}

27:14-16 {} She is as elusive as wind, as slippery as oil on the fingers.	27:15-16 (Translation) {} {} 16 [She is like] a north wind, And his right hand chances [only] upon oil.
--	--

{}

	27:17 (Translation) {}
--	----------------------------------

{ "One implication of this is that we do not need friends who [are] just like us, or who never correct or challenge us... We need to have our rough edges knocked off" (Wilson 287).

	27:18 (Translation) {}
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	27:19 (Translation)
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	27:20 (Translation) $\{\}$
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$$\{$$

	27:21 (Translation) {}
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$$\{$$

	27:22 (Translation)
	{ }

$$\{$$

	27:23 (Translation)
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$$\{$$

	27:14 (Translation)
	{

$$\{$$

	28:1 (Translation) The wicked flees when one is pursuing, But the righteous are as bold as a lion.
--	---

$$\{$$

	28:2 (Translation) With the sin of a lands its rulers become many, While with a man of discerning intellect—in this way its days are lengthened.
--	--

Cf. Warring States period (not a justification of Xi)

“In just over two centuries, northern Israel, for its sins, had nine dynasties, each, after the first, inaugurated by an assassination (see God's comments in Hos 7:7; 8:4; 13:11). In three and a half centuries, Judah, for David's sake, had only one” (Kidner 161).

	28:3 (Translation) {
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$$\{$$

	28:4 (Translation)
	{

“Without revelation, all is soon relative; and with moral relativity, nothing quite merits attacks. So, e.g., the tyrant is accepted because he gets things done; and the pervert, because his condition is interesting. The full sequence appears in Romans 1:18-32” (Kidner 162).

	28:5 (Translation) {
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$$\{$$

	28:6 (Translation) { }
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$$\{$$

	28:7 (Translation) {
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These words of Hubbard's (261) might be exaggerated, but only slightly: "Intimacy entails vulnerability. It subjects us to roller-coaster emotions. Our spirits are so intertwined with those of our parents and children that what happens to them happens to us. Their highs are ours, and so are their lows. Their behavior is the barometer of our well-being. Nothing sparks joy so much as their love and goodwill; nothing triggers pain like their rejection and rebellion."

	28:8 (Translation) {
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	28:9 (Translation) {
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 $\{$

	28:10 (Translation) {
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$$\{$$

	28:11 (Translation) {
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 $\{$

	28:12 (Translation) When the righteous rejoice, there is great glory, But when the wicked rise up, men hide.
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 $\{$

	28:13 (Translation) {
--	---------------------------------

 $\{$

	28:14 (Translation) {}
--	--------------------------------------

{}

	28:15 (Translation) {}
--	--------------------------------------

{}

	28:16 (Translation) {}; He who hates {} will lengthen [his] days.
--	--

{}

	28:17 (Translation) {}
--	--------------------------------------

{}

	28:18 (Translation) {}
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{}

	28:19 (Translation) {}
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{}

	28:20 (Translation) {}
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{}

	28:21 (Translation) {}
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{}

	28:22 (Translation) {}
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{}

	28:23 (Translation) He who reproves a man finds favor later on More than the man who flatters with his tongue.
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{}

	28:24 (Translation) {}
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{

	28:25 (Translation) {
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}

	28:26 (Translation) The one who trusts his own mind—he is a fool; But the one who walks in wisdom—he will be saved.
--	--

}

	28:27 (Translation) He who gives to the poor—he has no lack; But he who hides his eyes—many curses!
--	--

}

	28:28 (Translation) When wicked men arise, a human being hides; But when they vanish, the righteous multiply.
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}

	29:1 (Translation) {
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}

	29:2 (Translation) When the righteous are numerous, a people rejoices; But when a wicked man rules, a people groans.
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}

	29:3 (Translation) A man who loves wisdom makes his father glad, But a friend of prostitutes erases generational wealth.
--	---

}

	29:4 (Translation) A king establishes a land in justice, While a deceptive man tears it down.
--	--

}

	29:5 (Translation) The man who slanders his neighbor Spreads a net under his {
--	---

}

	29:6 (Translation) In the rebelliousness of an evil man is a snare, While the righteous man will rejoice happily.
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{ }

	29:7 (Translation) A righteous man understands the vindication of the poor; A wicked man does not grasp knowledge.
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	29:8 (Translation) { }
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{ }

	29:9 (Translation) When a wise man faces a foolish man in court, There is turmoil, and mockery, and no quiet.
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{ }

	29:10 (Translation) Men of blood[shed] hate the man of integrity, And as for the upright—they seek their life [to kill them].
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{ }

29:11 (Paraphrase) The foolish person rushes onward with explosive emotion; the wise person holds back with careful thought.	29:11 (Translation) A fool brings out all his spirit, But a wise man, sitting back, soothes it.
--	--

The wise person and the fool probably feel the same emotions, but it is generally best not to act *immediately* on the full weight of them. As the English-language proverb has it, “Discretion is the better part of valor.”

	29:12 (Translation) A ruler who listens to a deceptive matter— All his assistants are wicked men!
--	--

The type of authority figure likely to countenance a lie is a man who likely has surrounded himself with dishonest men. Leaders and institutions which have a tortured relationship with facts ought to be avoided.

	29:13 (Translation) The poor man and the oppressive man have met together; The one who gives light to the eyes of both of them is Yahweh.
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{ }

	29:14 (Translation) A king who adjudicates in truth for the weak— His throne will be established forever.
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{ }

	29:15 (Translation) The rod and reproof gives wisdom, But the young man left to his own devices brings shame to his mother.
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{ }

	29:16 (Translation) { }
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{ }

29:17 (Paraphrase) Do the hard work of disciplining your kids now, and later they will bring you true friendship.	29:17 (Translation) Correct your son, and he will [later] give you rest, And will give pleasure to your soul.
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“If you want to enjoy your children all your life, start by lovingly disciplining them early” (Wiersbe 125).

	29:18 (Translation) { }
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{ }

	29:19 (Translation) { }
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{ }

	29:20 (Translation) Have you seen a man who is hasty with his words? There is more hope for a fool than for him.
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	29:21 (Translation) { }
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{ }

	29:22 (Translation) { }
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	29:23 (Translation) { }
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	29:24 (Translation) { }
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	29:25 (Translation) { }
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{ }

	29:26 (Translation) { }
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{ }

	29:27 (Translation) { }
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	30:1 (Translation) The words of Agur son of Yakeh— The <i>massa</i> [runs thus:] The man says, “I am { }
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{ }

	30:2 (Translation) { }
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{ } “The point God seems to make in these questions is that no unaided human knowledge can probe these mysteries—a theme sounded in Job 28” (Hubbard, 459). Hubbard (459) points to Mat 11:27.

	30:3 (Translation) { }
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{ }

	30:4 (Translation) { }
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{ }

	30:5 (Translation) Every word of God is { }; He is a shield to all who take refuge in him.
--	---

{ }

	30:6 (Translation)
--	---------------------------

{

	30:7-9 (Translation) { { 8 { { 9 { {
--	---

}

	30:10 (Translation)
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{ ““before I die’ means ‘as long as I live’” (Hubbard, 460).

	30:11-14 (Translation) { { 12 { { 13 { { 14 { {
--	---

}

	30:15-16 (Translation) The leech has two daughters, [named] “Give” [and] “Give!” Three things will not be satisfied; [No,] four have never said “Enough!”: 16 [1] Sheol, [2] a retrained womb, [3] A land not satisfied with water, [4] And fire, which never says “Enough!”
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}

	30:17 (Translation) An eye which mocks his father and scorns the old age of his mother, The ravens of the valley will dig it out, And the vulture's offspring will eat it.
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}

	30:18-20 (Translation) { {
--	---

	19 {} {} 20 {} {}
--	--

“Some commentators... have sought a common denominator in the idea of movement which leaves no trace behind; but it would be better sought in that of the easy mastery, by the appropriate agent, of elements as difficult to negotiate as air, rock, sea—and young woman. The fifth, and unnatural, marvel ([v]20) is that of a person utterly at ease and in her element in sin; an act of adultery is as unremarkable to her as a meal (20b, c)” (Kidner 173). Regarding “easy mastery” of things “difficult to navigate,” one might think of Simone Biles who, after performing an astonishing gymnastic feat, smiles. Without taking away from the tremendous effort someone like Biles in fact puts into her craft, there is a sense in which it comes naturally to certain members of humanity to do certain things that most people could hardly imagine themselves doing. The variety of abilities, talents, and gifts scattered abroad by God is astonishing. But special notice must be taken of an event which down through history has often occurred, yet never in exactly the same way twice—the romance of a man and a woman. (The book of Song of Songs—also commonly, if correctly, known as the Song of Solomon—dwells on this phenomenon at length.)

Yet the depravity of sin, it must be said, takes one the best elements of human activity and perverts it, so that if the fourth astonishing thing Agur lists is man and woman, the fifth is adultery, and activity frequently, and often with devious skill, executed. Hence special care must be taken to maintain sexual purity.

	30:21-23 (Translation) {} {} 22 {} {} 23 {} {}
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“The Bible delights in fruitful reverses of fortune... but has no use for upstarts... who become too big for their boots” (Kidner 174).

	30:24-28 (Translation) {} {} 25 {} {} 26 {} {} 27 {} {} 28 {} {}
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{}

	30:29-31 (Translation) {} {} 30 [1] A lion, warrior among the land animals, Who does not turn away before anything;
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	31 [2] A rooster; [3] a billy goat; [4] And a king standing before his people.
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{ }

	30:32-33 (Translation) { } { } 33 { } { }
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{ }

	31:1 (Translation) { }
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{ }

	31:2-9 (Translation) { } { } 3 { } { } {see suggestion in HALOT 2: 1909a) 4 Not for kings, O Lemuel, Not for kings is the drinking of wine, And for rulers there is to be no {strong drink}. 5 { } { } 6 { } { } 7 { } { } 8 { } { } 9 { } { }
--	---

	31:10-31 (Translation) { } { } 11 { } { } 12 { } { } 13 { } { } 14 { } { } 15 { } { }
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	16 {}
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	17 {}
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	18 {}
	{}
	19 {}
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	20 {}
	{}
	21 {}
	For all her house is clothed with double-layered clothing.
	22 {}
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	23 {}
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	24 {}
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	25 {}
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	26 {}
	{}
	27 {}
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	28 {}
	{}
	29 {}
	{}
	30 {}
	{}
	31 Celebrate her because of the fruit of her hands, And let them praise her works in the gates.

{ }

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